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SCAN FOR LOCATION

UTTAR PRADESH

India's Fastest Growing-State Over the Last 8 Years

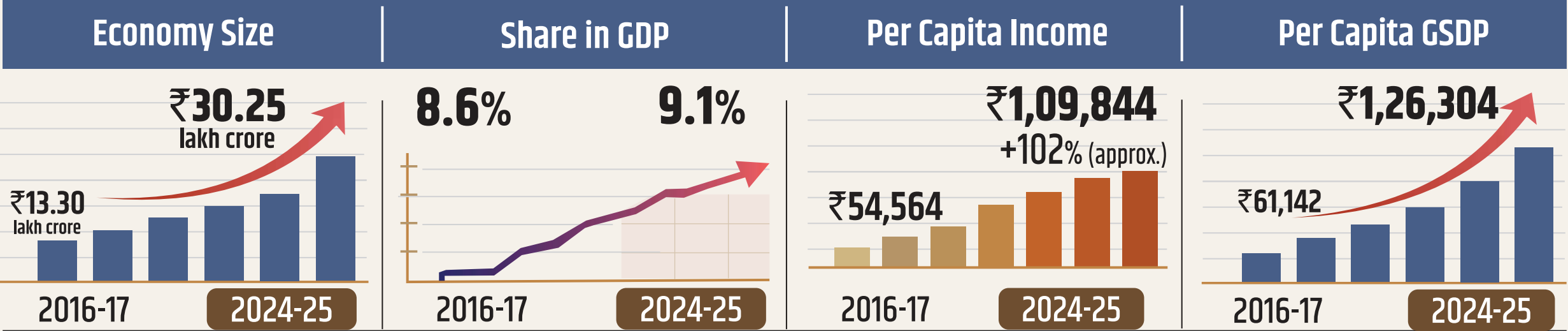
An overview of Uttar Pradesh's economic transformation and regional development

Uttar Pradesh's Economy more than doubled since 2017

Uttar Pradesh is experiencing rapid economic growth supported by agriculture, industry, and technological expansion. The state's economy represents the aspirations of more than 25 crore citizens, strengthened by agriculture, industrial development and technological innovation. U.P. has created a diversified economic base while social initiatives provide measurable indicator. Over the past decade, the state economy has transitioned from a consumption-driven structure to an investment-led growth model. Public infrastructure expansion, private industrial participation and rural income support have collectively strengthened economic resilience and broadened the base of growth.



ECONOMY AT A GLANCE

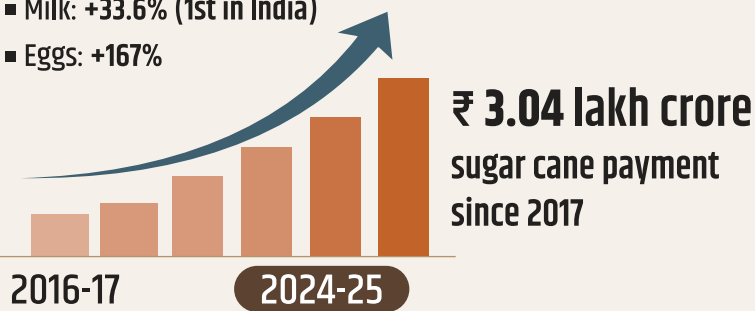


Contribution to National GDP increased from 8.6% to 9.1% • Per capita income has seen a remarkable rise

Agricultural Success

Agriculture continues to serve as the backbone of the state economy, supporting livelihoods while contributing significantly to food security and agro-based industry. Productivity improvements, irrigation expansion and farmer support measures have strengthened rural purchasing power and stimulated demand across markets. U.P. is leading agricultural producer in food grains, wheat, sugarcane, potato, banana, mango, guava, amla and mentha.

- Food Grain: +115.5%
- Sugar Industry: 956.09 lakh tonnes
- Cropping Intensity: 162.7% → 193.7%
- Irrigated Area: 2.16 → 2.76 crore hectare
- Crushing capacity: 92.45 lakh tonnes production
- Milk: +33.6% (1st in India)
- Eggs: +167%



Excellence in Education

Human capital development remains central to long-term growth. Expansion of universities, training centres, and sports infrastructure aims to improve employability and skill readiness.

- 38 State Universities
- 52 Private Universities
- 163 Apprenticeship centres
- 918 Trainees cleared competitive exams

Major Dhyan Chand Sports College expansion and One District One Playfield initiative aim to prepare youth for emerging opportunities.

Infrastructure Revolution

Large-scale infrastructure projects aim to improve connectivity and regional accessibility across urban and rural areas.

- 5 International airports (4 operational & 1 in progress)
- First underground rapid rail in Varanasi
- Expressway expansion across the state



Bundelkhand Industrial Development Authority development Land Acquisition ongoing
Renewable energy share: 23% → 27%

Industrial Progress

Industrial development has emerged as the second major growth pillar. The number of factories increased from 14,169 to 30,695, while manufacturing GVA grew by 25%. Exports rose from ₹0.84 lakh crore to ₹1.86 lakh crore (2017-2025). The One District One Product (ODOP) programme generated approximately 3.22 lakh jobs.

- Factories: 14,169 → 30,695
- Manufacturing GVA: +25%
- Exports (₹ Lakh Crore): 0.84 → 1.86 → 1.31 (2025-26 Nov)
- At the 2026 World Economic Forum, Uttar Pradesh attracted investment commitments totalling ₹2.94 lakh crore.
- ODOP: 3.22 lakh jobs

Major Achievements Snapshot

- 3rd consecutive Achiever in LEADS Index 2024
- Record plantation: 37.21 crore saplings
- Highest PM Awas houses constructed
- 1.85 crore free LPG connections (Ujjwala)
- DBT agricultural subsidy leader
- GeM procurement leader
- Ayodhya Deepotsav Guinness World Record (26.17 lakh lamps)
- 10.22 crore Jan Dhan accounts (No.1)

Investment Momentum

- Industrial investment proposals exceeding ₹50 lakh crore
- Uttar Pradesh emerging as an investment-friendly state

Social Empowerment

26.81 lakh girls benefited under Kanya Sumangala

Free hostel facilities for 9,432 students

Scholarships to 24.69 lakh students

11 lakh OBC students to benefit (2025-26)

Uttar Pradesh's growth is supported by agriculture, expanding industry, and services-sector participation
"Towards a Developed Uttar Pradesh by 2047"

the hindu businessline

SENSEX 82814.71 (+316.57)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	25571.25	+116.90
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	22.74	+0.09
US Dollar (in ₹)	90.98	+0.32
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	154445.00	+494
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	250314.00	+5542

BULLION RALLY.

Gold and silver prices firmed up on US-Iran tensions, while inflows into gold ETFs rebounded in second week of Feb **p10**



AUTO FOCUS.

Toyota enters India's EV space with Urban Cruiser EBella, focused on comfort and range **p4**

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QUICKLY.

DEEPENING TIES

India joins Pax Silica to secure chips, key minerals



New Delhi: India and the US on Tuesday signed the Pax Silica declaration at the India AI Impact Summit, formally marking New Delhi's entry into a strategic partnership to secure resilient supply chains for semiconductors, artificial intelligence (AI) and critical minerals. Both sides projected it as an initiative to curtail over-dependence on "one country", the oblique reference presumed to be to China. **p2**

POSITIVE MOMENTUM

Near-term economic outlook favourable: RBI

Mumbai: The near-term outlook for the economy is favourable and is well-positioned to sustain its high growth momentum, driven by consumption, investments and reforms, wrote RBI staffers in the latest monthly bulletin. The MPC's February 6 resolution revised upwards the growth projections for Q1 (April-June) FY27 and Q2 (July-September) by 0.2 per cent each, to 6.9 and 7 per cent, respectively. **p7**

In 6-3 ruling, US Supreme Court strikes down Trump's global tariffs

OVER-REACH. The court ruled that the law under which Trump imposed tariffs intruded on the powers of Congress

Reuters
Washington

LEGAL SETBACK. The judges, in a 6-3 ruling, upheld a lower court's decision that President Donald Trump's use of the 1977 law exceeded his authority **REUTERS**

The US Supreme Court on Friday struck down President Donald Trump's sweeping tariffs that he pursued under a law meant for use in national emergencies, rejecting one of his most contentious assertions of his authority in a ruling with major implications for the global economy.

The judges, in a 6-3 ruling authored by conservative Chief Justice John Roberts, upheld a lower court's decision that the Republican President's use of the 1977 law exceeded his authority.

TREADS ON CONGRESS

The court ruled that the administration's interpretation that the law — the International Emergency Economic Powers Act, or IEEPA — grants Trump the power he claims to impose tariffs would intrude on the powers of the Congress and violate a legal principle called the "major questions" doctrine.

The doctrine, embraced by the conservative judges, requires actions by the government's executive branch of "vast economic and political

significance" to be clearly authorised by the Congress. The court used the doctrine to stymie some of Democratic former President Joe Biden's key executive actions.

Citing a prior Supreme Court ruling, Justice Roberts wrote that "the President must 'point to clear congressional authorisation' to justify his extraordinary assertion of the power to impose tariffs," adding, "He cannot."

Trump leveraged tariffs as a key economic and foreign policy tool. They have been central to a global trade war that he initiated after he began his second term as President, one that has alienated trading partners, affected financial

markets and caused global economic uncertainty. The Supreme Court reached its conclusion in a legal challenge by businesses affected by the tariffs and 12 US States, most of them Democratic-governed, against Trump's unprecedented use of this law to unilaterally impose the import taxes.

The three dissenters were conservatives Clarence Thomas, Samuel Alito and Brett Kavanaugh. Joining Justice Roberts in the majority were conservative Justices Neil Gorsuch and Amy Coney Barrett, both of whom Trump appointed during his first term in office, along with the three liberal judges.

Trump's tariffs were forecast to generate trillions of dollars in revenue for the US over the next decade. The administration has not provided tariff collection data since December 14. But Penn-Wharton Budget Model economists estimated on Friday that the tariff amount collected stood at more than \$175 billion. And that amount likely would need to be refunded now.

The US Constitution grants the Congress, not the President, the authority to levy taxes and tariffs. But Trump turned to a statutory authority by invoking IEEPA to impose the tariffs on nearly every trading partner without the approval of the Congress. Trump has imposed some additional tariffs under other laws that are not at issue in this case.

EMERGENCY LEVY

IEEPA lets a President regulate commerce in a national emergency. Trump became the first President to use IEEPA to impose tariffs, one of the many ways he aggressively pushed the boundaries of executive authority since returning to office. He described the tariffs as vital for US economic security, predicting

that the country would be defenceless and ruined without them.

A DISGRACE: TRUMP

Trump called the ruling a "disgrace". After the Supreme Court heard arguments in the case in November, he said he would consider alternatives if it ruled against him on tariffs, telling reporters that "we'll have to develop a 'game two' plan."

Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent and other administration officials said the US would invoke other legal justifications to retain as many of Trump's tariffs as possible. These include a statutory provision that permits tariffs on imported goods that threaten US national security and another that allows retaliatory actions, including tariffs, against trading partners that the Office of the US Trade Representative determines have used unfair trade practices against American exporters. None of these alternatives offers the flexibility and blunt-force dynamics that IEEPA provided Trump, and may not be able to replicate the full scope of his tariffs in a timely fashion.

Also read **p9**

Novartis to sell entire 71% stake in listed India arm to ChrysCapital group for ₹1,446 crore

PT Jyothi Datta
Mumbai

Swiss drugmaker Novartis AG is set to sell its entire 70.68 per cent stake in Novartis India Ltd (NIL) to the ChrysCapital group for ₹1,446 crore.

The drug major said it had entered into an agreement with WaveRise Investments Ltd, ChrysCapital Fund X and Two Infinity Partners to sell the India listed entity, and expects the transaction to be completed by the third quarter of 2026, subject to certain conditions.

The acquiring companies have also announced an open offer, as mandated, to pick up the remaining shares in the company.

Novartis will continue to be present in India through Novartis Healthcare Private

Ltd (NHPL), a wholly owned subsidiary through which the company has been bringing its high-value innovative products into India.

INNOVATION COMPANY

Upon completion of the transfer of shares, Novartis will complete its transformation into a pure-play innovative medicines company aligned with its global strategy, with a focus on cardio-renal-metabolic and oncology products. The transfer of Novartis AG shareholding in NIL will not impact NHPL, it reiterated.

In 2024, Novartis Chief Executive Vas Narasimhan said the company had completed its strategic transformation into a pure-play innovative medicines company, focused on cardiovascular-renal-metabolic, immunology, neuroscience and oncology, with the US, China, Germany and Japan identified as geographies of growth.

Novartis was formed when Swiss majors Ciba-Geigy AG and Sandoz AG merged in 1996. Ciba's history in India goes back to 1947, industry voices point out. NHL was formed in 1997, and its innovative drugs portfolio includes cancer, immunotherapy and gene therapy products. Granular details on the 40 employees with NIL and the branded products with them remain unclear, the industry voice added.

TRANSACTION DETAILS

Novartis has agreed to sell 1,74,50,680 fully paid-up equity shares in Novartis India, representing 70.68 per cent of the equity share capital of the company and proposed entering into a 'Deed' involving certain obligations of the company in connection with the transaction.

WaveRise Investments will acquire 1,39,38,382 equity shares, representing 56.45 per cent, at ₹860.64 per equity share.

The second acquirer will buy 25,47,189 equity shares representing 10.32 per cent of the equity share capital of the company at a price of ₹701.25 per equity share, and the third acquirer will buy 9,65,109 equity shares representing 3.91 per cent of the equity share capital at ₹701.25 per equity share, the announcement said.

PEELING PRICES



RISING PRODUCTION. Shallots being unloaded at the old mandi in Tiruchi's Gandhi Market on Friday. Shallot prices are ruling at ₹30-32 a kg with the new crop coming in from Thuraiyur. Prices are lower this year as production is estimated to be higher on account of conducive weather. During the same time a year ago, prices were ruling at over ₹50 a kg **VENGADHAR**

AI Summit gets a taste of Q-comm at Zepto's dark store

Attendees order food via app, avoiding crowds at the food court

Sindhu Hariharan
New Delhi

BUSY HUB. At 1,300 sq ft, the store is smaller than Zepto's dark store formats but handled over 1,700 orders on Thursday

With long treks to session venues and iffy golf-cart availability, every AI summit visitor needed a regular recharge, and with the food courts packed, it came from an unexpected avenue.

Quick commerce major Zepto set up its dark store at the AI Summit at Bharat Mandapam in Delhi and from snacks and beverages to even proper meals via Zepto Cafe, the store had almost everything a conference attendee needed.

INSTANT SUPPLIES

As this reporter stood at the store, along with the hectic flow of beverage orders to keep attendees refreshed, came the occasional emergency demands for printouts, duct tapes and more. From power banks and sta-

tionery items to even microphones, the store had almost every conference essential one could think of.

At roughly 1,300 sq ft, the store is smaller than a typical Zepto dark store, yet on Thursday, it handled over 1,700 orders. The number

consistently surged over the last three days.

GRAB AND GO

Opposite Hall 3 of the Expo is a small makeshift area, teeming with people in purple, waiting to pick up and deliver orders. People

thronged the store hoping to quickly pay and grab their orders, but Zepto fulfils deliveries from the store through 11 pickup points spread across the convention hall.

The store helped people quickly get snacks and even lunch, as the food courts at the venue were packed, and it took up to 30 minutes to pay for and collect food from them.

DIFFERENT LAYOUT

As orders came in, the picking and packing staff at the Zepto store quickly scanned and processed the items, which were clearly organised.

With smaller, quick consumption items needed in bursts of demand, the space was also laid out differently from the regular Zepto dark store, which typically stocks groceries.

In major rejig, UPL to merge India, global crop protection businesses; arm to be listed

Our Bureau
Mumbai

UPL has announced a restructuring plan that will consolidate its India and international crop protection businesses and create a pure-play, focused crop protection platform, which will be listed on the bourses.

The scheme of arrangement will create two listed entities — UPL, the existing listed diversified agriculture and speciality chemicals platform, and UPL Global, the dedicated crop protection platform. Existing investors of UPL will be issued one new share of UPL Global for every share they hold.

DEMERGER PLAN

Initially, the Group will amalgamate UPL Sustainable Agri Solutions into UPL, then vertically demerge the India crop protection business from

UPL into UPL Global. Finally, the international crop protection business, UPL Corp, will be merged with UPL Global.

The transaction is expected to be completed in 12-15 months, subject to timely receipt of regulatory approvals.

The UPL Board of Directors on Friday approved the group reorganisation plan through a composite scheme of arrangement with the objective of unlocking value for its shareholders by creating an independent and focused crop protection platform.

The reorganisation will enable clearer value discovery by providing flexibility to the investors to select investment that best suit their investment strategy and risk profile. The integrated business will benefit from the company's strong manufacturing base, advanced research capabilities, a robust global product portfolio and



Jai Shroff, Chairman and Group CEO, UPL

independent management.

The scheme will also sharpen managerial and board focus while enabling UPL Global to broaden its capital base by attracting a wider pool of investors, strategic partners and lenders, supporting sustained business growth.

FUTURE-READY

Jai Shroff, Chairman and Group CEO, said that unifying the India and international crop protection businesses under UPL Global will

create a future-ready platform with the focus, agility and innovation needed to lead in a rapidly evolving market. This move sharpens strategic focus, aligns stakeholder interests and positions both UPL and UPL Global for disciplined, value-accretive growth in the years ahead, he said.

GLOBAL NO 2

Mike Frank, CEO, UPL Global, said the merger of the crop protection businesses will create the world's second largest listed pure-play crop protection platform with a presence in over 140 countries and enable the company deliver innovations to farmers faster and more efficiently to gain greater market share.

Bikash Prasad, Group CFO, said the structural simplification strengthens the financial foundation and accelerates the company's journey to be more efficient.

QUICKLY.

‘India can double share in global media with AI’



New Delhi: India has the opportunity to double its share in the global media market through bold adoption of artificial intelligence, said JioStar India Vice-Chairman Uday Shankar, urging industry stakeholders to embrace disruption rather than resist it. The global media market is valued at nearly \$3 trillion and is projected to reach \$3.5 trillion by 2029, he said. “India’s share is currently less than 2 per cent. AI offers the potential to explore our share in this pie. Even a modest shift in our share of global revenue from 2 per cent to 4 per cent or 5 per cent would represent tens of billions of dollars in new value creation and could be transformational for a large segment of our people,” he said. However, the JioStar official also said that this opportunity and outcome are not the same, and to seize the moment, “we need all stakeholders pulling in the same direction”. **en**

India joins US-led Pax Silica to secure chips, critical minerals

DEEPENING TIES. Coalition aims to cut supply chain risks by reducing dependence on ‘one nation’

Our Bureau
New Delhi

India and the US on Tuesday signed the Pax Silica declaration at the India AI Impact Summit, formally marking New Delhi’s entry into a strategic partnership to secure resilient supply chains for semiconductors, artificial intelligence (AI) and critical minerals. Both sides projected it as an initiative to curtail over-dependence on “one country”, the oblique reference presumed to be to China.

The pact was signed by IT Secretary S Krishnan and US Under Secretary of State for Economic Affairs Jacob Helberg, in the presence of Union Minister for Electronics & Information Technology Ashwini Vaishnaw and US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor.

SECURING SUPPLIES

Pax Silica was launched in December with Australia, Greece, Japan, Qatar, South



The pact was signed by IT Secretary S Krishnan (right) and the US Under Secretary of State for Economic Affairs Jacob Helberg (left) in the presence of Minister for Electronics & IT Ashwini Vaishnaw and US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor (centre) **ANI**

Korea, Singapore, the United Kingdom and the United Arab Emirates, besides the US and the latest entrant India as members.

Pax Silica, literally ‘Peace through Silicon’, is being positioned as a technology compact aimed at securing semiconductor supply chains and AI infrastructure

among trusted democratic partners. The broader geopolitical subtext of Pax Silica is unmistakable in the face of China’s predominant role in rare earth processing, advanced manufacturing inputs and much of the global semiconductor value chain.

While no country was named in the formal re-

marks, US Under Secretary Helberg flagged challenges arising out of “massively over-concentrated” supply chains for critical minerals and “threats of economic coercion and blackmail”.

Though Helberg did not name any country, it was clear that his remarks were pointed at China.

Helberg described Pax Silica as a commitment to economic and national security that rejects “weaponised dependency” in global supply networks.

“For too long, we have allowed the foundations of our economic security to drift. We find ourselves grappling with a global supply chain that is massively over-concentrated,” he said. The Trump administration official spoke of cities plunged into darkness “by a key-stroke from across the border,” underscoring concerns about cyber and infrastructure vulnerabilities.

“So, today, as we signed the Pax Silica declaration, we say no to weaponised de-

pendency, and we say no to blackmail,” Helberg said.

STRATEGIC ALIGNMENT

For India, the move signals a calibrated deepening of technological alignment with the US and its partners. Vaishnaw highlighted India’s expanding capabilities in chip design and the growing pool of skilled technology professionals, positioning them as assets not just for domestic growth, but for collaborative global value chains under the Pax Silica framework.

Ambassador Gor said India brings strength to the coalition. “Peace doesn’t come from hoping adversaries will play fair. We all know they won’t. Peace comes through strength. India understands this. India understands strong borders,” said Gor.

Industry leaders, including Google CEO Sundar Pichai, said that alongside the recent interim trade agreement, this will lay a strong foundation for a robust US-India tech partnership.

‘Centre planning legal framework to address cyber security challenges’

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

The Centre is planning to create a legal framework to address cyber security challenges and opportunities, and is in discussions with industry stakeholders for the same, said Ashwini Vaishnaw, Minister for Electronics and Information Technology on Friday.

“We also have to create a new legal framework for cyber security with all these challenges that we are facing today and the new opportunities that we have. Time has come when we, as a government and industry, need to align together to handle these threats,” said Vaishnaw at the unveiling of AI and Cyber Threat Research Centre on the sidelines of the India AI Impact Summit.

CYBER RESILIENCE

The Research Centre is being set up by Bharti Airtel and cloud security firm Zscaler AI, with an aim to advancing India’s national cyber resilience, protect critical sectors (like telecommunications, banking and energy), secure

digital users and accelerate the adoption of trusted AI across India’s growing digital ecosystem.

Vaishnaw said all IT and telecom companies should seriously consider handling new forms of cyber security challenges, and such centres will help the country in the long run.

Meanwhile, Sunil Bharti Mittal, Chairman, Bharti Airtel, said the research centre is a part of the corporate social responsibility of Airtel and Zscaler.

‘NOT COMMERCIAL’

“This is not a commercial venture. But Zscaler and Airtel are committed to fund this whole initiative. I am sure more and more people will join. We already have received interest from many other enterprises in our country. It’s more in the area of philanthropy or CSR that we do from Airtel’s side and Zscaler from their side,” said Mittal.

He also said that Airtel’s research-backed preventive mechanism will also encourage peaceful and secure engagements on digital platforms.

‘Sovereign AI means building trusted partnerships, not isolation’

bl.interview

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

Evan Solomon, Canada’s Minister for AI and Digital Innovation, has been advocating the importance of Sovereign AI. Solomon, who is taking part in the AI Summit, outlines the scope for Indo-Canadian cooperation, balancing rapid AI adoption with risk mitigation and the preservation of national digital autonomy.

Edited excerpts:

You’ve highlighted the potential for a practical partnership between India and Canada in areas such as AI and emerging technologies. Have your discussions

with IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw yielded specific progress?

Minister Vaishnaw and I have spoken a number of times and are currently developing a series of MoUs to map out our cooperation. We share a common goal of building Sovereign AI, and making sure that we have options and not [depend on] just one customer from one country. Also, we are making sure we have Canadian Sovereign [AI strategy] and Indian Sovereign, and those require really deep partnerships. For instance, we have Tata Consultancy Services working in Canada with almost 10000 people. We are working to build our stacks together. We value that kind of cooperation.

How do you define

Sovereign AI, and how will India and Canada complement each other in this pursuit?

Sovereignty doesn’t mean isolation. It means having trusted partnerships and options. It is about controlling your digital destiny and AI destiny, from building efficient data centers to owning the IP of your applications.

Canada is one of the only four countries with major large language model Co-here, which offers a global alternative [to US or Chinese tech]. Partnerships between countries can help in the entire process of ensuring sovereignty, such as education, research, building a stack, creating the IP and keeping it in your country. And this is why Canada and India and some other countries are allies. This is the reason why we signed a sovereign tech-



Safety is a pillar of sovereignty. While both India and Canada are developing regulations, we also need technical solutions

EVAN SOLOMON

Canada’s Minister for AI and Digital Innovation

nology alliance with Germany a few days ago.

With growing concerns over AI safety, what measures are being taken to mitigate risks? Safety is a pillar of sovereignty. While both India and Canada are developing regulations, we also need tech-



nical solutions. At this summit, world-renowned AI scientist Yoshua Bengio is here with us to present LawZero, an AI designed specifically to police other AI systems.

Canada will financially support it. We have a letter of intent to be one of the main backers of this. Other countries are coming on board as

well. So, this is one part of sovereignty, which is an AI to make sure that AI keeps us safe. Your Minister, too, says he believes there needs to be a technical solution to AI safety as well as a legislative one. So, we are hoping that India will come on board as well.

Can LawZero also protect data security and personal privacy?

So, the LawZero technology will really tell you if AI is about to do something that is harmful. But in terms of protecting data, your privacy and your information, that’s going to be the job of the government.

So, we have some legislation coming that will update our privacy laws to make sure that Canadians have the right to have their data safe, have their privacy safe and

have some transparency around how AI is using your data. You need both a technical solution, where we are investing, and a governance solution.

How is Canada addressing the threat of AI-driven job losses, a major concern for populous nations like India?

History shows that every technological revolution ultimately creates more jobs than it destroys. However, the anxiety is real. Governments must prioritise skills training and education. In this initial wave of AI, those who can use the technology will have a distinct advantage over those who cannot. Because the technology is evolving so rapidly, we cannot discuss AI without investing in human capital.

AI will not make humans redundant, says Cisco’s Jeetu Patel

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

AI will not render humans obsolete, but it must have strong guardrails with trust embedded at its core as it can amplify human capability if built responsibly, said Jeetu Patel, one of the top AI strategists in the world. “I reject the notion that the advancement of AI means the extinction of human contribution to society,” said Patel, the President and Chief Product Officer of Cisco.

He said AI must operate at machine scale while remaining deeply human-centric. While consumer-facing tools such as chatbots dominate public imagination, Patel said Cisco’s role lies in building the infrastructure that powers the AI ecosystem.

RENDEZVOUS WITH ROBOTS



MACHINE MARVELS. Visitors check out robots in one of the stalls at the India AI Impact Summit on Friday **SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA**

‘Virtual technology is the key to building semiconductor talent’

Our Bureau
Chennai

The complexity of modern semiconductor manufacturing means that India, with fewer fabrication plants and research labs, will need to leverage virtual technologies to build semiconductor talent, according to David Fried, Corporate Vice-President, LAM Research.

TRAINING NECESSARY

Fried was speaking at the India AI Impact Summit, where he emphasised on the

need for training and leveraging domestic talent for India to achieve semiconductor ambitions.

“Physical fabrication tools can be expensive and limited. Instead, students and engineers can now learn key processes such as deposition and polishing, experiment with multiple parameters, and understand interactions in a safe and scalable environment using digital models” he said.

LAM Research had, in 2023, signed an agreement with the Government of India to train 60,000 Indian en-

gineers in semiconductor design and manufacturing technology. Fried added that the company has already partnered with over 85 universities, and has surpassed training milestones two years ahead of time.

TALENT REQUIREMENT

At the panel, Ashwini Vaishnaw, Minister of Electronics and Information Technology, said the global semiconductor industry will have talent requirements of up to one million people by 2031, and the government’s aim is to supply most of this.

UAE plans to deploy 8 exaflop-capacity supercomputer in India

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Abu Dhabi has announced plans to set up a national-scale AI supercomputer in India with peak compute capacity of 8 exaflops, marking a new phase in India’s AI infrastructure development.

The project marks a transition to exaflop-scale AI infrastructure in India, expanding the country’s domestic compute capabilities for advanced AI development. This supercomputer’s capacity will be four times the capacity of El Capitan at Lawrence Livermore National Laboratory, the

world’s fastest supercomputer until late 2025, achieving over 1.8 exaflops of performance.

SECURITY NORMS

The system will operate under India-defined governance frameworks, with all data remaining within national jurisdiction. Designed to meet sovereign security and compliance requirements, the supercomputer will serve as a foundational asset under the India AI Mission.

Announced during the summit, the supercomputer will be delivered by G42, Abu Dhabi-based global technology group, and Cerebras,

makers of the world’s fastest AI inference, in partnership with Mohamed Bin Zayed University of Artificial Intelligence and India’s Centre for Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC).

It follows the 5th India-UAE Strategic Dialogue held in December 2025 and the visit of UAE President Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan to India in January 2026. “Sovereign AI infrastructure is becoming essential for national competitiveness. This project brings that capability to India at a national scale, enabling local researchers, innovators and enterprises to

become AI-native while maintaining full data sovereignty and security,” said Manu Jain, CEO of G42 India.

WIDE ACCESS

Once operational, the supercomputer will be accessible to the nation’s diverse ecosystem, from premier institutions to start-ups, small and medium enterprises and government ministries. This democratised access model is designed to lower barriers to AI innovation, particularly for applications serving India’s 1.4 billion citizens.

“Strategically, this would position India not merely as an AI consumer, but also as a

sovereign compute hub capable of training frontier scale models domestically, reducing hyperscaler dependence and strengthening regulatory control over sensitive workloads,” said Sanchit Vir Gogia, Chief Analyst and Founder at Greyhound Research.

businessline.

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QUICKLY.

Army showcases AI-driven applications

New Delhi: From a climatology and disaster prediction system to a device that detects driver's fatigue to avert accidents, the Army has showcased a slew of artificial intelligence-based applications at the AI Impact Summit here, with Defence Minister Rajnath Singh visiting the Army pavilion on Friday. The Indian Navy has also put up a pavilion as part of the summit expo. **PTI**

Dell Technologies unveils 'AI India Blueprint'

New Delhi: Dell Technologies unveiled its 'AI India Blueprint' at the India AI Impact Summit 2026, outlining a national execution framework to scale artificial intelligence as a core pillar of the country's digital public infrastructure (DPI) and support the nation's long-term development goals under Viksit Bharat 2047. The blueprint, titled Advancing India's AI Future: A Blueprint for Trusted, Secure and Nationwide Success, proposes a structured approach to move India's AI ecosystem from pilot projects to population-scale deployment, positioning AI as a shared national capability rather than isolated technology initiatives. **PTI**

AI is no magic; IT services will be the last mile in agentification: Cognizant

TRANSITION MANTRA. AI moving from being magic to an engineered design principle, says Babak Hodjat

Sindhu Hariharan
New Delhi

Enterprises are coming to the realisation that AI is no magical "pixie dust" and customisation with business processes is key to reap benefits of Agents, Cognizant's Chief AI Officer Babak Hodjat said.

Speaking to *businessline* on the sidelines of the AI Summit here, Hodjat said that IT services companies "own the last mile" and understand the client's domain inside out, and that context is the missing piece in the 'agentification' journey.

"Agents need to be designed and defined to model the processes and organisations of our clients, and it needs to be done in a trustworthy way. There's customisation, tailoring, engineering, safeguarding that has to happen," he added.

Cognizant, he said, is not just ready for this transition but also "ahead of everyone else," noting their investments in this regard including in AI labs.

Cognizant recently opened its India AI Lab in



Bengaluru. The India AI Lab extends Cognizant's AI Lab in San Francisco, which was recently granted its 61st US patent.

ON PARTNERSHIPS

Speaking about the company's recent partnerships with various AI native startups including Anthropic, Hodjat called it a win-win tie-up. "While we are empowering our associates to use the models and bringing them to our clients, Anthropic also wants to be a serious, reliable player in the enterprise world, and we can help them with that," he said. The AI chief at the Nas-

daq-listed major said they are not just using AI internally for employees and project delivery but also measuring the impact of it on net new logos [clients]. "We're measuring how much we're actually making use of AI and delivering to our clients and what kind of productivity we are bringing to the table," he said.

Laying down the ways in which the company, which has majority employees in India, is preparing its workforce for the transition, Hodjat said they are running boot camps, hackathons, and also specialised context engineering courses.



We're looking at freshers and bringing a whole bunch of them into the company because they understand and use AI much more naturally

BABAK HODJAT,
Cognizant's Chief AI Officer

Another way is by actually hiring more, he points out. "We're looking at freshers and bringing a whole bunch of them into the company because they understand AI and they use AI much more naturally," he said.

While higher up in the pyramid, there's scepticism and there's reluctance and conservatism, lower down you have 'naivety,' he said. However, this can be tackled by the right training and we need that energy and innovation, he added.

AI LABS ECOSYSTEM

Speaking about the AI Labs ecosystem, Hodjat called it a

place where they do core AI research.

One major breakthrough they had recently seen is in fine-tuning large language models, where "the Lab invented a new way to fine-tune that uses Evolutionary Strategies instead of Reinforcement Learning."

This method, essentially, is less compute-hungry. "In India, in particular, we're researching multi-objective reasoning systems where you're trying to reason for more than one outcome at the same time, and we are also looking at joint research with IITs and others," he said.

In India, the AI Labs core team is around 30 people, mainly AI PhDs and researchers, and some AI engineers. "We want the research to be cutting edge, and want it to be grounded in what our clients are looking for," he said.

And what stands in the way of completing the transition from IT services to AI services? "We just need that expectation to be tapered down — that AI is not magic but just an engineered principle," he said.

PM holds bilateral talks with several leaders

Press Trust of India
New Delhi



Prime Minister Narendra Modi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday held talks with top leaders of Mauritius, Sri Lanka and Slovakia with a focus on shoring up bilateral cooperation in trade and technology sectors.

He also held a meeting with UN Secretary General Antonio Guterres and discussed how the global body can play a "constructive role" in making use of artificial intelligence inclusive.

Modi met Guterres and other leaders on the sidelines of the AI Impact Summit.

"We talked about making AI all inclusive and how the UN can play a constructive role in this regard," the Prime Minister said on his talks with the UN chief.

"Reiterated India's support towards any effort aimed at harnessing AI for a better planet. We also exchanged perspectives on UN reforms, especially giving greater voice to the Global South," he said on social media. Following his talks with Mauritius Prime Minister Navinchandra Ramgoolam, Modi said both sides will continue to work in close cooperation to ensure regional security and prosperity.

"Delighted to meet Prime Minister of Mauritius Navinchandra Ramgoolam. Reaffirmed our shared commitment to take our enhanced Strategic Partnership to new heights in AI, technology, culture and people-to-people ties," he said.

Modi also described Mauritius as a vital partner in India's MAHASAGAR (Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions) vision.

On his meeting with Sri Lankan president Anura Kumara Dissanayake, the Prime Minister said: "We took stock of the progress in India-Sri Lanka relations in the recent times." "We also discussed avenues of cooperation in areas such as energy, connectivity, infrastructure, healthcare, skilling, culture, blue economy and more," he added.

Farmers start taking decisions on AI-based forecasts as accuracy improves: Chaturvedi

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Farmers have started taking decisions related to farming on the government's weather forecasts as accuracy has increased after using artificial intelligence, said Union Agriculture Secretary Devesh Chaturvedi. The government now plans to incorporate more areas such as market prices and arrivals in the advisories to help improve the decision-making capabilities of farmers.

Addressing a session at the India AI Impact Summit, Chaturvedi said, "We used the 100 years data of the India Meteorological Department, which Google CEO earlier mentioned about predicting weather, on a model to predict monsoon for next one week, and one month. Those predictions were fairly accurate."

"We received feedback that farmers took their decisions on sowing and irrigation based on those predictive model's forecasts. Now, we will expand these forecasts to include advisories on market situation and weather situations to help improve the decision-making capacities of farmers. This will help them raise productivity and reduce costs."

ESSENTIAL COMMODITIES

Sources said that the Agriculture Ministry had tried to predict prices of essential commodities, such as onion, potato and tomato, using AI,



Now, we will expand these forecasts to include advisories on market situation and weather situations to help improve the decision-making capacities of farmers. This will help them raise productivity and reduce costs

DEVESH CHATURVEDI, Agriculture Secretary

as recommended by the Dalwai committee on Doubling Farmers' Income. However, it could not be launched as there were discrepancies in historical data at micro levels, the sources said.

But experts believed that it was a risky decision politically as forecasts would be coming from the government or its agency and in case of 20-30 per cent variance, it might create a controversy.

Chaturvedi also said that Bharat-VISTAAR is currently disseminating weather advisories, ICAR's crop advisories, on pest management, market information on produce traded in the

mandis, and schemes of the Central government.

BENEFITS OF AI

On why AI in agriculture is important, he explained that it would help remove "digital red-tapism" as every section/division even within the Ministry used to have separate mediums of information dissemination. Farmers had a lot of difficulties to go to each website or app to find out the information, he added.

Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan inaugurated the 'Bharat VISTAAR' scheme, unveiled the farmer-centric AI Hackathon and the Agri Kosh AI

Strategy Roadmap at an event in Jaipur, Rajasthan, on February 17. 'Bharat VISTAAR' was announced in the Budget speech by Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on February 1.

Terming the AI-based Bharat-VISTAAR launch as the first stage, Chaturvedi earlier said that it would be connected with Agristack, where all data are getting stored from farmer identity cards. In the next six months, farmers would be able to get guidance and solutions to their problems related to agriculture from AI technology after calling a helpline number from a registered mobile. Details of their data like land size, crops grown and fertilizers bought will be available, which will be accessed by the system automatically when called from the registered mobile, and accordingly queries will be answered.

Currently, Bharat VISTAAR is available in Hindi and English, but gradually it will cover all the regional languages, with a target to cover additional nine languages in the next six months.

It provides information on mandi rates, weather information, various Central schemes, the application status of farmers for any scheme, and the 'Package of Practices' developed by ICAR scientists. Besides the helpline number, it can be downloaded directly as an Android app or accessed through the website.

AI impact: Tech chiefs reject claims of crisis in the IT services model



TAKING STOCK. (from left) Salil Parekh, CEO of Infosys Ltd; K Krithivasan, CEO of TCS; C Vijayakumar, CEO of HCL Technologies Ltd; and Arundhati Bhattacharya, Chairperson and CEO of Salesforce India, at the AI Impact Summit in New Delhi on Friday **BLOOMBERG**

Sindhu Hariharan
New Delhi

Leaders of information technology (IT) majors, including TCS, Infosys, HCL Tech and Salesforce, strongly rejected the growing claim that AI will make IT services or the software-as-a-services (SaaS) industry redundant.

Speaking as part of a panel discussion at the AI Impact Summit, the leaders suggested that markets react for various reasons and the stock price movements do not give any particular message.

Further, when quizzed about their plans to ramp up R&D and capex spends, the leaders said they keep looking at opportunities and time R&D spends accordingly.

"I am not too sure the market is giving the right message. It is a little too hasty to say vibe coding can

solve all of customer problems. Vibe coding tools cannot understand customer pain points," Arundhati Bhattacharya, President & CEO at Salesforce, South Asia, said at a panel discussion of IT leaders in the AI Summit.

Salesforce, like many other IT stocks, has seen a significant decline in price in the last few weeks as major leaps in the AI tools such as Claude and others place a question mark on the future of Indian IT services and SaaS players.

TRANSFORMATION

"You may not know all the rules that you will have 5 years down the line, but we do not envisage a situation where there will be a significant shrinkage of work or headcount," TCS CEO K Krithivasan said. He cited the example of the advent of cloud computing and noted

that the transformation is still on after so many years. "They [organisations] have to get their data estate right, they have to get their applications rationalised, modernised, so there is a certain amount of work to be done," he said.

Infosys' Salil Parekh said the IT major sees several areas of opportunity coming from AI services, which could be about \$300 billion of opportunity over the next several years. This opportunity needs more talent, and they have recruited 20,000 college graduates this fiscal, and next year, are on track to recruit 20,000 college graduates.

HCL Tech MD and CEO C Vijayakumar highlighted how the IT company is uniquely placed.

"We are uniquely placed because we have a software product business which delivers 10 per cent of our rev-

enue and also have a very deep engineering heritage, where we service top 50 of the 100 R&D spenders," he said.

"There are still gaps; these large language models and the foundational models, cannot be applied most efficiently for enterprise use cases," he said.

JOB LOSS FEARS

With regard to the job loss fears, Krithivasan said that one should not let the fear of AI paralyse them. "You can be afraid and not do anything, but I think we should be forward leaning and train as many people as possible," he said.

As for big tech's massive capex spends and whether Indian IT will follow suit, Vijayakumar said that as proliferation of AI grows, there will be more outcome-based pricing and thus more profitability and R&D spends.

IBM, BharatGen, NxtGen to help AP build Swadeshi AI stack

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

The Andhra Pradesh government has announced that it will work with technology major IBM, large language model developer BharatGen, and cloud and AI service provider NxtGen to support its plans to build a Swadeshi AI stack, a sovereign AI technology framework.

This stack will enable citizen-centric AI solutions in Telugu and other regional languages while strengthening governance and service delivery across priority sectors. The Swadeshi AI stack aims to build core AI capabilities customised to the country's linguistic and cultural context.

STRATEGIC ADVICE

The State government signed the agreements with three companies at the AI Impact Summit 2026 being held in New Delhi on Friday.



AI EMPOWERMENT. Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu with representatives of IBM, BharatGen and NxtGen at the AI Impact Summit in New Delhi on Friday

As part of the collaboration, IBM, BharatGe and NxtGen will offer technical and strategic advice to the government regarding the design, architecture and operating model of the Swadeshi AI stack.

"IBM will support this initiative by bringing its technologies and expertise in

data and AI, hybrid cloud, governance, automation and security," an IBM executive said.

SOVEREIGN AI MODELS

BharatGen is strengthening the Andhra Pradesh government's Swadeshi AI Stack with sovereign AI models. These models are developed

in India to represent the nation's many languages and cultures. BharatGen's multilingual foundation models, with native support for Telugu and other Indian languages, form the intelligence layer of this collaboration. It will help government departments, start-ups, academia and industry to co-create cit-

izen-centric solutions.

NxtGen will support this initiative by enabling secure, India-hosted cloud and GPU infrastructure optimised for AI training and inferencing workloads.

SECURED SERVICES

"This collaboration marks an exciting step toward creating a sovereign, citizen-first AI ecosystem rooted in India's languages and values. We are laying the foundation for secure, inclusive and hyperpersonalised public services," Nara Lokesh, Minister of IT, Electronics and HRD, Government of Andhra Pradesh, said.

"Swadeshi (indigenous) models and sovereign GPU infrastructure are key enablers for building innovative solutions, scaling adoption and transforming government services, while still tailoring to unique local needs," Sandip Patel, Managing Director, IBM India and South Asia, said.

AP signs 7 MoUs on skilling, quantum infra; IIT-Madras to introduce AI Tutor

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

The Andhra Pradesh government has signed seven memoranda of understanding (MoUs) on skilling and infrastructure development for quantum computing at the India AI Impact Summit 2026 in New Delhi on Friday.

"The seven agreements are expected to help Andhra Pradesh become a major Quantum-AI centre, developing the Quantum Valley in Amaravati," a State government official said.

NIELIT UNIVERSITY

The State government also signed an agreement with the National Institute of Electronics and Information Technology (NIELIT) to set up a Quantum AI University in the State. It will be the first AI and Quantum deemed university campus in the

South. The Central government will provide funds for infrastructure, while the State government will provide land and quantum hardware.

NIELIT Director General Madan Mohan Tripathi and Controller General Alok Tripathi were present at the MoU signing event.

AI TUTOR

IIT-Madras will introduce an AI Tutor in Andhra Pradesh, which will be made available to students in both government and private schools across the State.

"The government is also going to train students and young people in AI and quantum technologies, preparing them for future job market demands. The State will focus on using AI and quantum technologies in government departments to simplify how public services are delivered," a State gov-

ernment official said.

The United Nations International Computing Centre (UNICC) will establish a Centre of Excellence in quantum and AI by the end of the year. UNICC Director Sameer Chauhan and representatives of the organisation attended the MoU signing ceremony.

IBM will train one lakh youth in the State in quantum technologies, AI and cybersecurity through its global digital learning platform. IBM India Managing Director Sandeep Patel, its South Asia Executive Director Kishore Balaji and IBM Research Labs Director Amit Singhee discussed the programme's details with Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu at the event.

In another agreement, Calibo AI agreed to set up AI Academies and AI Sandboxes in 50 higher educational institutions in the State.

QUICKLY.

BMW X3 30 xDrive M Sport Pro launched at ₹74.5 lakh

BMW India has introduced the X3 30 xDrive M Sport Pro, positioning it as its new range-topping petrol variant. It is priced ₹2 lakh



above the xDrive 20 and on par with the diesel xDrive 20d. The SUV is powered by a 2.0-litre four-cylinder turbo-petrol engine producing 258 bhp and 40.8 kg-m, paired with an

8-speed automatic transmission, a 48-volt mild-hybrid system and BMW's xDrive all-wheel drive. BMW claims a 0-100 kph time of 6.3 seconds. The variant features a blacked-out illuminated grille, 20-inch alloy wheels, red M brake callipers and smoked lighting elements. Inside, it gets M seat belts, updated soft-touch trims, a panoramic roof, a 360-degree camera, three-zone climate control, digital displays and a Harman Kardon sound system.

Jeep Meridian Track Edition starts at ₹35.95 lakh

Jeep India has launched the Meridian Track Edition at ₹35.95 lakh for the automatic variant and ₹37.82 lakh for the automatic 4x4



(ex-showroom). Based on the Overland trim, the new edition brings cosmetic updates and added comfort features. Exterior changes include piano-black accents on the grille and badges,

18-inch diamond-cut alloy wheels, a Dark Espresso grille with Neutral Grey highlights and a Track Edition hood decal. Inside, the SUV gets a new dual-tone Tupelo theme with suede inserts and a Cortina leather-wrapped steering wheel with contrast stitching. A key addition is a 140 mm sliding second row to improve cabin flexibility. The Track Edition continues with the 2.0-litre diesel engine paired with a 9-speed automatic transmission.

Vespa Officina 8 available at ₹1.34 lakh

Piaggio has launched the Vespa Officina 8 special edition in India. The scooter is available in a single matte metallic Blue Officina 8 shade



and comes with a matching helmet as standard. The name pays tribute to Officina 8, Piaggio's experimental workshop in Pontedera, Italy, established in 1944 and known for developing

early Vespa prototypes. The special edition features brass and aluminium accents, visible rivets and design elements inspired by the tools and machinery of the original workshop. It is offered in 125cc and 150cc versions, mechanically identical to the standard models. Buyers will also receive a welcome kit detailing the history of Officina 8. Matching accessories and merchandise are available separately through select Vespa dealerships across India.

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Ciao Bella

ALL EYES. Toyota's first-ever BEV in India is built for the world, says the firm. How does it hold up in its home country?

AMIT NAIK

Kurt Morris

Toyota's electric journey in India has taken a decisive step forward with the Urban Cruiser EBella. It represents the company's carefully measured entry into all-electric mobility, built around collaboration, localisation and, above all, long-term dependability.

Even the name carries layered meaning — 'EBella' draws inspiration from the Italian word bella, meaning 'beautiful'. It's a global blend — an Italian-flavoured name for a Japanese-engineered SUV built for India and the world. In many ways, the EBella reflects the modern automotive landscape itself; platforms and expertise shared across borders, shaped into products tailored for specific markets.

Our driving route in Bengaluru kept us away from the city's notorious traffic, allowing us to focus on what matters. Underneath, the EBella shares its architecture with a broader alliance platform. But in today's EV ecosystem, shared foundations are less about sameness and more about interpretation. Toyota's interpretation leans firmly toward comfort, trust and everyday usability, which are the brand's core values.

Visually, the EBella has a confident, contemporary presence. The front features Toyota's hammer-head-inspired design language, lending the SUV a clean and assertive identity. Slim LED daytime running lamps and sharply detailed headlamps frame the face, while the lower bumper design adds visual width and solidity. In profile, its



STAY TUNED. The Toyota Urban Cruiser EBella delivers future-ready design, usable real-world performance, strong safety credentials and, crucially, the Toyota trust factor

AMIT NAIK

proportions remain balanced and uncluttered. Some substantial cladding (which could have been more subtle) and clean surfacing prevent the design from feeling overstyled.

The 18-inch alloy wheels fill the arches neatly, giving it a grounded stance without unnecessary aggression. At the rear, combination lamps integrate smoothly into a sculpted tailgate, while a robust bumper reinforces durability. The overall design feels quite cohesive, restrained and engineered to age gracefully.

Step inside and the EBella's focus on comfort becomes clear. A dual-tone interior theme creates a welcoming ambience, enhanced by a sunroof (not fully panoramic) that adds a sense of space for all occupants. The 10.1-inch infotainment system forms the digital centrepiece, paired with a JBL sound system, wireless charging, 12-colour ambient lighting and other essentials. A floating centre

console improves storage while lending the cabin a visual lightness. A distinctive two-spoke 'squirrel' steering wheel adds character without compromising ergonomics. Driver comfort is a highlight — the 10-way power-adjustable front seat includes ventilation. Physical controls for climate and volume functions are retained, a welcome decision in an era of touchscreen-only interfaces.

There are, however, minor usability quirks. Activating seat ventilation requires navigating multiple touchscreen menus, something that would benefit from a dedicated physical switch. Similarly, USB ports beneath the floating console are very awkward to access. These are small points in an otherwise thoughtfully laid-out cabin. Rear passengers are well catered to. The 40:20:40 split seats slide and recline, offering flexibility between comfort and luggage space. Material quality feels robust and well as-

sembled, reinforcing Toyota's reputation for longevity.

BUYER ECOSYSTEM

The EBella will be offered with two battery packs: 49 kWh and 61 kWh, both paired with a single electric motor. The larger battery produces 172 bhp and 19.68 kg-m, with a claimed range of up to 543 km.

While our drive time was limited, the range calibration appeared realistic. On the move, the EBella delivers the smooth, near-silent acceleration expected from a modern EV. Power delivery is linear and predictable, making urban driving effortless. Instant torque ensures stress-free overtaking. Drive modes include Eco, Normal, and Sport, allowing drivers to tailor response levels. A single-pedal driving mode increases regenerative braking, proving useful in traffic while aiding efficiency. Ride comfort stands out; the suspension tuning feels well-suited to Indian conditions,

and the battery's thermal management system, along with protective underbody shielding, ensures composure over uneven roads. Safety remains central to the package; seven airbags are standard, supported by Level 2 ADAS, a high-tensile steel structure and chassis tuning focused on stability.

Toyota has also developed a comprehensive ownership ecosystem. Buyers get Assured Care service coverage, 24x7 roadside assistance offered nationwide by BEV-trained technicians. Maintenance is designed to be efficient, with periodic services completed in approximately 45 minutes. Battery concerns are addressed through warranty coverage, battery-as-a-service options and assured buyback or residual value programmes. Charging support includes home solutions, dealership infrastructure and partnerships with ChargeZone and Jio-bp to expand fast-charging access.

The Urban Cruiser EBella's philosophy is clear. Rather than chasing headline performance figures, Toyota has prioritised practicality, comfort and reassurance.

That measured strategy mirrors its successful hybrid journey in India, which was based on steady adoption built on trust. The car may not be the most dramatic EV in its segment, but that restraint is its strength. It delivers future-ready design, usable real-world performance, strong safety credentials and, crucially, the Toyota trust factor.

With pricing expected soon, the Urban Cruiser EBella positions itself as a serious and sensible contender in India's evolving electric SUV landscape.

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Breaking Habit

BUYER CHALLENGER.

Hero's Destini 110 aims to disrupt scooter-buying muscle memory



CUSHIONS THE RIDE. The 110.9 cc motor pulls cleanly and smoothly all the way up to 80 kph without any vibrations, delivering the performance of a cool cruiser



Manaal Mahatme

In a segment where familiarity sells by the lakh every single month, trying to stand out is less about being better and more about being different enough to be noticed. This is a space ruled by habit, where buyers return to the same showroom almost on autopilot, trusting a formula that has worked for decades. For Hero, breaking into this rhythm hasn't been about a single strong swing, but persistence. The Destini 110 is the brand's

third attempt at cracking the 110 cc scooter code.

Within Hero's own lineup, the positioning is pretty straightforward. While the Xoom 110 is aimed squarely at young boys and the Pleasure is designed to appeal to the fairer sex, the Destini is meant to speak to the entire family.

Visually, the Destini 110 is a breath of fresh air in a segment that doesn't demand unique or striking design. It resembles a slightly shrunken-down Destini 125, and that's not a bad thing at all. The LED projector headlight flanked by vertical LED DRLs

gives it a premium face, while the generous use of chrome adds just enough flair without tipping into excess. Then there are bits like the external fuel-filler cap and backrest for the pillion that show the scooter hasn't forgotten convenience in the pursuit of being eye candy. But more importantly, the fit-and-finish levels feel solid and consistent — an area where buyers in this segment are almost unforgiving. It looks mature, well put together and expensive enough to justify a second glance.

But the Destini isn't just pleasant to look at. It's genuinely enjoyable to live with around the

city. The seat is long enough for taller riders to scoot back and still carry a pillion comfortably, and that's a small but important detail many scooters get wrong.

Ergonomics are another strong point. Even at full lock, the handlebar doesn't foul with the knees, making tight U-turns and slow-speed manoeuvres stress-free. The floorboard space is decent, too, with enough room for large feet to move around without feeling boxed in.

SMOOTH OPERATOR

The highlight, however, is the engine. The 110.9 cc motor pulls

cleanly and smoothly all the way up to 80 kph without any vibrations. It's only after brushing past the 90-kph mark that vibrations start creeping in through the floorboard and handlebar — but realistically, this scooter isn't going to spend much time there. More importantly, even with a pillion onboard, the engine doesn't feel strained or overwhelmed. It delivers exactly the kind of predictable, usable performance that suits its intended role.

Ride quality is reassuringly good for a scooter. The suspension does a commendable job of dealing with broken roads, speed

breakers and everything in between, without feeling floaty or unsettled. Braking performance inspires confidence as well.

While the front disc offers adequate stopping power, it's the rear drum that feels particularly strong and effective in real-world riding. Add to this the 12-inch wheels shod with grippy CEAT Zoom X3 tyres, and the Destini feels agile and eager — qualities that matter far more in city traffic than outright speed.

Price is where the Destini 110 makes its strongest argument. At ₹79,000 (ex-showroom, Delhi) for the top ZX variant, it under-

cuts expectations by offering a scooter that looks good, feels agile and performs well enough to make you momentarily forget it's a 110cc machine and not a 125. Where it does have to fight harder is on the features front. The analogue console and modest under-seat storage won't win spec-sheet battles, but they also don't get in the way of what the Destini does well. And in a segment ruled by habit and muscle memory, sometimes being different enough is exactly what it takes to finally break the autopilot mentality.

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India-US interim trade deal likely to be operational in April: Goyal

DUTY RELIEF. Commerce Minister hopeful that Washington will roll back tariffs on Indian goods to 18% soon

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

Commerce & Industry Minister Piyush Goyal has expressed hope that the India-US interim trade deal would be signed in March and operationalised in April.

Indian exporters, however, are still waiting for the US to bring down reciprocal tariffs to 18 per cent from the current 25 per cent, which officials confirmed was likely to happen much before the finalisation of the interim pact, as agreed to between the two sides.

“The US had agreed to reduce reciprocal tariffs on Indian goods to 18 per cent independent of the interim deal and ahead of it. We expect it to happen any time,” an official tracking the mat-

ter said. Goyal, too, confirmed that the lowering of import tariffs to 18 per cent was likely to happen in February.

Of the 50 per cent tariffs on Indian products imposed in August-September 2025, the US formally rolled back 25 per cent punitive levies linked to the purchase of Russian oil earlier this month. India's negotiating team, led by chief negotiator Darpan Jain, will be in Washington on February 23 to meet the US team and sort out remaining issues in the interim deal to finalise the legal text of the agreement, the official added.

Goyal criticised Opposition leader Rahul Gandhi for questioning India's commitment to buy goods worth \$100 billion from the US every year as part of the trade



Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal

deal without a similar commitment from Washington, and accused him of being detached from the real issue.

The Minister said that lowering of US additional tariffs on Indian goods from 50 per cent to 18 per cent (as part of the deal) was a huge relief to Indian exporters of labour-intensive goods.

Moreover, the US would also bring down tariffs to

zero per cent on India's gems and diamonds and spices as part of the interim trade deal, he added.

PLANNED IMPORTS

Goyal said the planned imports of items such as GPUs, tech equipment, aircraft and coking coal from the US were things that the country needed. “India has safeguarded all the sensitive sec-

tors (in the India-US trade deal). It is a great win-win solution for both countries,” he said.

Earlier this month, India and the US released a joint statement announcing a framework for an interim trade agreement. While the reduction of reciprocal tariffs on Indian goods drew cheer from exporters, some farmer groups raised concerns on the commitments on farm products.

“India will eliminate or reduce tariffs on all US industrial goods and a wide range of US food and agricultural products, including distillers dried grains with solubles, red sorghum for animal feed, tree nuts, fresh and processed fruit, soybean oil, wine and spirits, and additional products,” the joint statement noted.

Govt rolls out 7 steps to boost exports

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The government on Friday announced seven measures, including credit assistance for e-commerce exporters and support for alternative trade instruments, to promote the country's outbound shipments.

These measures are part of the ₹25,060 crore export promotion mission. Out of 10 components of the mission, three have already been rolled out in January.

DIGITAL PUSH

To support exporters using digital channels, the Commerce Ministry announced credit facilities with interest subvention and partial credit guarantees.

The Direct E-Commerce Credit Facility will provide support up to ₹50 lakh with 90 per cent guarantee coverage.

The Overseas Inventory Credit Facility will extend support up to ₹5 crore with 75 per cent guarantee coverage, and an interest subven-

tion of 2.75 per cent will be available, subject to an annual ceiling of ₹15 lakh per applicant, the commerce ministry said.

To promote export factoring as an affordable working capital solution for MSMEs, an interest subvention of 2.75 per cent will be provided on the factoring cost for eligible transactions undertaken through RBI/IFSCA-recognised entities.

Assistance is capped at ₹50 lakh per MSME annually and will be processed through a digital claim mechanism to ensure transparency and timely disbursement.

To support emerging export opportunities, the Ministry said this intervention enables exporters to access new or high-risk markets through shared-risk and credit enhancement instruments such as Letters of Credit confirmation and negotiation.

For Trade Regulations, Accreditation and Compliance Enablement (TRACE), support will be extended to exporters in meeting international testing, inspections,

certifications and other conformity requirements.

IMPORT-EXPORT CODE

Under this, partial reimbursement of 60 per cent under the Positive List and 75 per cent under the Priority Positive List will be provided for eligible testing, inspection and certification expenses, subject to an annual ceiling of ₹25 lakh per IEC (import export code).

Facilitating Logistics, Overseas Warehousing and Fulfilment (FLOW) will enable exporters to access overseas warehousing and fulfilment infrastructure, including E-Commerce Export Hubs integrated with global distribution networks, it said.

Under this, an assistance of up to 30 per cent of the approved project cost will be provided for a maximum of three years, subject to prescribed ceilings and MSME participation norms.

For exporters from northeastern and hilly regions, Logistics Interventions for Freight and Transport (LIFT) was announced.

As Russian oil flows to India dwindle, Saudi Arabian shipments likely to hit 6-year high

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

As Indian imports of Russian crude oil narrow due to US and EU sanctions, shipments of the geopolitically-sensitive commodity from Saudi Arabia are expected at around one million barrels per day (mb/d) in February,

the highest in more than six years.

New Delhi has turned towards its traditional suppliers in West Asia, particularly Saudi Arabia, Iraq and the UAE, to replace Russian barrels. Another beneficiary is the US.

To top it, Saudi Aramco slashing Arab Light's official selling price to Asia by \$0.30

a barrel for March, on par with the Oman/Dubai benchmark, reflects Riyadh's efforts to address competition amidst rising global supply.

Global real time data and analytics provider Kpler anticipates that Russian oil crude imports into India are estimated around 1-1.2 million barrels per day (mb/d) in February, easing towards

roughly 800-1,000 thousand b/d (kb/d) in March.

KEY SUPPLIER

“However, we continue to see this as a short-term stabilisation rather than a return to the mid-2025 peak, and we expect Russia's share in India's crude slate to gradually stabilise to a lower range in 2026 compared to

2024-25 as commercial and policy frictions build,” it added.

Russia emerged as India's main crude oil supplier in the last few years with Iraq, Saudi Arabia and the UAE filling the next three spots. Recently, Washington displaced Abu Dhabi to take the fourth spot.

With the US sanctions on

Russian oil giants Rosneft and Lukoil coming into effect in November 2025 and the EU's 19th sanctions package becoming effective last month, India's crude oil imports dynamics is undergoing another transition.

Sumit Ritolia, Kpler's Lead Research Analyst for Refining & Modeling, told *businessline*: “Saudi Arabia

has already regained its position as India's top supplier in February month-to-date data. As of February 19, Saudi volumes are tracking around 1.4 mb/d, marking the highest level since November 2019.” However, Kpler expects some moderation in the coming weeks, with a few parcels likely slipping into early March, he added.

“On a full-month basis, our predictive flows model currently indicates Saudi imports averaging closer to around 1-1.1 mb/d in February, still a multi-year high,” Ritolia emphasised.

The immediate replacement for softer Russian flows has largely come from the Middle East, particularly Saudi Arabia, he pointed out.



Invesco Mutual Fund

Invesco Asset Management (India) Pvt. Ltd.

(CIN: U67190MH2005PTC153471), 2101-A, 21st Floor, A Wing, Marathon Futurex, N. M. Joshi Marg, Lower Parel, Mumbai - 400 013

Telephone: +91 22 6731 0000, Email: mfservices@invescoindia.com; www.invescomutualfund.com

NOTICE-CUM-ADDENDUM

NOTICE is hereby given to the investors / unit holders that Invesco Trustee Pvt. Ltd., (**the Trustee to Invesco Mutual Fund**) has decided to carry out following changes in the Scheme Information Document (“**SID**”) and Key Information Memorandum (“**KIM**”) of Invesco India Focused Fund, An open ended equity scheme investing in maximum 20 stocks across market capitalization (i.e. Multicap) (“**the Scheme**”) of Invesco Mutual Fund (“**the Fund**”) with effect from **March 30, 2026**:

Change in the features of the Scheme

The features of the Scheme will be changed as follows:

Sr.#	Particulars	Existing Scheme Features	Proposed Scheme Features
1.	Name of the Scheme	Invesco India Focused Fund	Invesco India Focused Fund
2.	Type of Scheme*	An open ended equity scheme investing in maximum 20 stocks across market capitalization (i.e. Multicap)	An open ended equity scheme investing in maximum 30 stocks across market capitalization (i.e. Multicap)
3.	Investment Objective*	To generate capital appreciation by investing in upto 20 stocks across market capitalization. There is no assurance that the investment objective of the Scheme will be achieved.	To generate capital appreciation by investing in upto 30 stocks across market capitalization. There is no assurance that the investment objective of the Scheme will be achieved.
4.	Investment Strategy*	The Scheme will be actively managed. The Scheme seeks to generate capital appreciation from a concentrated portfolio of upto 20 stocks, which may result in higher risk. The Scheme will adopt a multi-cap investment approach with a flexibility to invest across large, mid and small cap companies. The stock selection will be guided by our investment philosophy and proprietary stock categorization framework. Our process driven approach and categorization framework will assist us in filtering the high conviction investment ideas and contain the downside risk. The Scheme will adopt a fully invested approach comprising of both growth and value stocks.	The Scheme will be actively managed. The Scheme seeks to generate capital appreciation from a concentrated portfolio of upto 30 stocks, which may result in higher risk . The Scheme will adopt a multi-cap investment approach with a flexibility to invest across large, mid and small cap companies. The stock selection will be guided by our investment philosophy and proprietary stock categorization framework. Our process driven approach and categorization framework will assist us in filtering the high conviction investment ideas and contain the downside risk. The Scheme will adopt a fully invested approach comprising of both growth and value stocks.
5.	Product Labelling	This product is suitable for investors who are seeking*: - Capital appreciation over long term - Investments primarily in equity & equity related instruments across market capitalization subject to maximum 20 stocks *Investors should consult their financial advisers if in doubt about whether the product is suitable for them.	This product is suitable for investors who are seeking*: - Capital appreciation over long term - Investments primarily in equity & equity related instruments across market capitalization subject to maximum 30 stocks *Investors should consult their financial advisers if in doubt about whether the product is suitable for them.
6.	Scheme Specific Risk factors	1. Concentration Risk The scheme is expected to run a significantly concentrated strategy comprising of a maximum of 20 stocks. This will likely mean stock weights on average being materially higher than underlying benchmark weights. This may lead to higher volatility in scheme's performance and divergence of portfolio performance vis-à-vis the benchmark over different periods. The scheme structure may also differ on sector exposures compared to those in the benchmark.	1. Concentration Risk The scheme is expected to run a significantly concentrated strategy comprising of a maximum of 30 stocks. This will likely mean stock weights on average being materially higher than underlying benchmark weights. This may lead to higher volatility in scheme's performance and divergence of portfolio performance vis-à-vis the benchmark over different periods. The scheme structure may also differ on sector exposures compared to those in the benchmark.

* Considered as Fundamental Attribute Change

All other features, terms and conditions of the Scheme will remain unchanged.

The Board of Directors of Invesco Asset Management (India) Pvt. Ltd. and the Board of Directors of Invesco Trustee Pvt. Ltd. have approved the proposed changes. The Securities and Exchange Board of India (“**SEBI**”) vide its email dated **February 12, 2026** has communicated its no-objection for the proposed changes.

In accordance with the provisions of Regulation 18(15A) read with Regulation 25(26) of SEBI (Mutual Funds) Regulations, 1996 (“**SEBI Regulations**”), the change in ‘Type of the Scheme’, ‘Investment Objective’ and ‘Investment Strategy’ in the SID amounts to change in fundamental attributes of the Scheme.

In line with regulatory requirements, for Scheme where a change in fundamental attributes is being proposed, we are offering an exit window (“**Exit Option**”) to the Unit holders of 30 days from **February 26, 2026 to March 27, 2026** (both days inclusive) (“**Exit Option Period**”). These changes will be effective from **March 30, 2026 (“Effective Date”)**. During the Exit Option Period, unit holders not consenting to the change may either switch to any other scheme of the Fund or redeem their investments at applicable Net Asset Value without payment of exit load subject to provisions of applicable cut-off time as stated in the SID of the Scheme. All transaction requests received on or after **March 30, 2026** will be subject to applicable exit load (if any), as may be applicable to the Scheme.

During the Exit Option Period, the Unit holders have following options:

- Redeem their units [partly or fully] at applicable NAV;
- Switch their units [partly or fully] to any of the Schemes of the Fund at applicable NAV; or
- Remain invested in the Scheme.

It is clarified that if the units of the Scheme are purchased during the period commencing from **February 26, 2026** and closing on **March 27, 2026**, applicable exit load will be levied even if such units are redeemed during the Option Exercise Period.

Unit holders who do not opt for redemption/switch-out on or before 3.00 p.m. on **March 27, 2026** shall be deemed to have consented to above changes and shall continue to hold units in the Scheme. **This offer to exit is merely an option and is not compulsory**. Invesco Asset Management (India) Pvt. Ltd. / Invesco Mutual Fund would like the unit holders to remain invested in the Scheme.

Unit holders who have pledged / encumbered their units will not have the option to exit unless they submit a letter of release of their pledges / encumbrances prior to submitting their redemption / switch requests. Investors who have registered for Systematic Investment Plan (SIP) in the Scheme and who do not wish to continue their future investments must apply for cancellation of their SIP registrations.

Redemption/switch out by the unit holders due to change in the fundamental attributes of the Scheme or due to any other reasons may entail tax consequences. In view of individual nature of tax consequences, Unit holders are advised to consult his / her / their professional tax advisor.

The individual communication regarding above changes is being dispatched or emailed to the unit holders of the Scheme whose names appear in the records of the Registrar, KFin Technologies Ltd., as at the close of business hours on **February 19, 2026**. Unit holders who do not receive the said communication or in case of any queries may contact Invesco Asset Management (India) Pvt. Ltd. 2101-A, A Wing, 21st Floor, Marathon Futurex N.M. Joshi Marg, Lower Parel, Mumbai - 400 013 or the Registrar, KFin Technologies Ltd. Unit: Invesco Mutual Fund, Selenium Tower B, Plot No 31 & 32, Gachibowli, Financial District, Nanakramguda, Serilingampally, Hyderabad - 500 032 or call our Toll Free No. 1800 209 0007 or email us at mfservices@invescoindia.com.

Pursuant to aforesaid changes, necessary changes will be carried out at relevant places in the Scheme Information Document and Key Information Memorandum of the Scheme.

This addendum forms an integral part of the Scheme Information Document / Key Information Memorandum of the Scheme as amended from time to time.

For Invesco Asset Management (India) Pvt. Ltd.
(Investment Manager for Invesco Mutual Fund)

Sd/-

Saurabh Nanavati

Managing Director & Chief Executive Officer

Date: February 20, 2026

Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

Capital move

Curbs on leveraged derivatives trading, a prudent move

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has revised regulations governing the exposure of scheduled commercial banks to capital markets. There can be no mistaking the context here — namely, the rampant increase in leveraged equity derivatives trading since the pandemic. Exposure of private sector banks to capital markets has grown at a compounded annual growth rate (CAGR) of 19.3 per cent between FY20 and FY25. Even PSU banks have grown their lending to this segment at a CAGR of 15.6 per cent in this period.



While private banks’ lending to capital markets stood at ₹1,91,945 crore as on March 2025, the exposure of PSU banks was ₹87,924 crore. This trend cannot be overlooked for its potential impact on banks’ stability. Not surprisingly, RBI is trying to restrain banks from ramping up their exposure. It has said that scheduled commercial banks should not finance buying of shares or trading by stockbrokers on their proprietary accounts. They are allowed to provide guarantees for proprietary trading, provided it is 100 per cent backed by collateral, 50 per cent of which should be in cash. There shall be strict monitoring of the collateral. RBI has also laid down the haircuts which should apply to securities given as collateral. These steps will help rein in banks’ capital market exposure along with the galloping trading volumes. The number of contracts traded in the equity derivative segment of the NSE has surged from 512 crore in FY20 to 10,329 crore in FY25, clocking a CAGR of 82 per cent annually. Proprietary trading by stockbrokers has been leading this surge in volumes, accounting for over 60 per cent of the derivatives trading and about one-third of the cash volumes on exchanges. The RBI has, however, been prudent; it did not clamp down on the entire broking industry. Instead, it has provided brokers with a lifeline, saying that banks can provide credit to finance their day-to-day operations, which include working capital facilities and finance for margin trading provided to clients, and to help them meet mismatches in settlement. Therefore, clients of brokers will not face a paucity of funds and the client-facing business of brokers will not suffer.

Yet, stockbrokers’ bodies have urged a rollback of the RBI rules, citing a potential hit to market liquidity and volumes. This is notwithstanding the fact that the Securities and Exchange Board of India has been concerned about equity derivatives trading, and since 2024 has come out with regulations to control speculation and protect smaller investors. So, the RBI is undoubtedly justified in imposing the latest lending curbs. Larger brokers who primarily concentrate on client servicing are unlikely to be impacted. Everyday operations of stockbrokers will be unaffected. Smaller brokers may struggle to give 100 per cent collateral for obtaining bank guarantees, and may have to reduce their trading activity. Fact is, some reduction in market volume is good for the well-being of the market, and for financial stability.

OTHER VOICES.

The Guardian

An emerging Berlin-Rome axis threatening EU’s green deal
When the European Union launched its green deal in 2019, putting into law the goal of climate neutrality by the middle of the century, it showed strategic foresight as well as global leadership. Russia’s war in Ukraine has starkly underlined the extent to which the continent’s energy security is dependent on the transition away from fossil fuels. Lately, however, EU leaders’ environmental approach appears to be echoing the youthful St Augustine’s plea on chastity: make us greener, but not yet. The recent European Industry Summit made unusually big headlines thanks to Sir Jim Ratcliffe’s xenophobic outburst over immigration. But it was also notable for fierce attacks on one of the most important pillars of EU environmental policy. The bloc’s emissions trading system (ETS) has achieved dramatic results in driving down overall emissions since 2005 and encouraging green innovation. (LONDON, FEBRUARY 19)

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL

The embarrassing truth about tariffs
The White House this week opened a new front in its war on the Federal Reserve: a fight about Fed research on the consequences of President Trump’s tariffs. If the tariffs are such an unambiguous economic and political winner, why is the Administration so defensive about them? The flap concerns the analysis we told you about last week by four economists at the Federal Reserve Bank of New York. They found that American households and businesses are bearing nearly 90% of the cost of the Trump tariffs, contrary to Mr. Trump’s claim that foreigners will pay. (NEW YORK, FEBRUARY 19)



NISHANT SAHDEV

New Delhi’s invitation to global companies to build AI data centres in India is being read as a confident move. The logic seems obvious: AI needs computational power, it needs large data centres to run, and India has the scale and space to host them. But countries that jumped early into building large numbers of data centres have learned a wallet-bruising lesson. AI infrastructure is not like roads or bridges. The technology changes fast, becomes outdated fast, consumes enormous energy, and depends heavily on the changing priorities of private tech firms. What looks simple on paper is far harder to manage in practice.

India has the advantage of watching others go first. That matters, because once projects reach a certain size, choices become harder to reverse. The real constraint today is not talent or ideas. It is steady power, cooling, water, stable grids, and available land. These are the pressure points. Large computing centres do not just sit implicitly in the background; they lean heavily on the country’s physical systems. A single modern facility can use as much electricity as a small city, and it needs that supply without pause. It does not power down during peak demand or summer shortages. Cooling runs day and night, often drawing deeply on local water. Once built, the ripple effects spread silently. Transmission lines are strengthened. Older power plants stay open longer. Water is diverted. Zoning rules changes. None of it feels shocking at the moment. It happens step by step.

LESSONS FROM ABROAD

Countries that moved early now see the full cost of those choices. What began as a digital bet has steadily changed grids, water systems, and land use — locking in physical consequences long after the headlines faded.

The US offers a clear warning sign. In 2023, data centres used about 176 terawatt-hours of electricity — roughly 4.4 per cent of the country’s total demand. That share is expected to climb sharply, possibly reaching 10-12 per cent within a few years as heavy computing loads grow.

The real issue, though, is not the national average. It is where this demand is concentrated. In Northern Virginia, home to the world’s largest cluster of data centres, these facilities already consume more than a quarter of the region’s electricity. To keep up, utilities have rushed to expand the grid, postponed the shutdown of fossil-fuel plants, and reworked how risk is priced.

The impact is already visible. Household electricity bills are rising faster than the national average, and grid planning now revolves around the demands of large computing facilities rather than homes or small businesses.



GETTY IMAGES

Think before scaling up AI data centres

WEIGH THE COSTS. Countries that moved early now see the full cost of those choices. What began as a digital bet has steadily changed grids, water systems, and land use

What began as a technology surge has turned into a broader power and pricing challenge.

Local governments first welcomed these facilities for the tax revenue. Over time, a different picture emerged: grid upgrades, substations, and transmission costs were largely shared across the system, while job creation remained modest compared to energy use. The infrastructure stayed. The leverage faded.

Ireland offers a parallel lesson. By 2022, data centres accounted for over 20 per cent of the country’s electricity demand, heavily concentrated around Dublin. Grid authorities warned that further expansion risked stability and climate goals. The response was practical, not ideological: new grid connections were paused in key areas. What had been sold as digital growth was redefined as a hard infrastructure limit.

Water tells the same story, only later and more sharply. In The Dalles, Oregon, Google’s facilities at times used nearly 30 per cent of the city’s water in a drought-prone area. Usage grew quietly under industrial permits, and public concern surfaced only once scarcity became visible — after contracts and infrastructure were already locked in.

The lesson is not that data centres are harmful. It is that their costs accumulate over time and spread widely, while their benefits arrive early and are captured by a few.

THE DYNAMICS IN INDIA

India must now ask what these dynamics would look like at home. Electricity in

During heatwaves, fuel shocks, or grid stress, hard choices are inevitable. Once large computing facilities are labelled “strategic infrastructure,” their access to power is rarely questioned

India is not a simple market commodity. It is a social bargain. Distribution companies are financially strained, tariffs are cross-subsidised, and power supply is deeply political — balancing households, farmers, and small businesses. Adding large, always-on data centres into this system does not just raise demand. It reshapes who gets priority.

During heatwaves, fuel shocks, or grid stress, hard choices are inevitable. Once large computing facilities are labelled “strategic infrastructure,” their access to power is rarely questioned. The adjustment cost shifts elsewhere — through outages, higher tariffs, or reduced reliability for ordinary users — often without public debate.

Water raises even sharper concerns. Many Indian cities already face seasonal shortages, and groundwater depletion is widespread. Large data centres can consume water at the scale of thousands of homes, yet this often remains invisible until scarcity becomes acute. In India’s context, water allocation to global computing workloads is not just a technical decision. It is a social and political one.

Fiscal policy adds another layer. In the US and Europe, governments offered tax breaks, discounted power, and infrastructure support to attract data centres. Early investment figures looked impressive. Over time, many regions found that public costs persisted while returns faded — especially given the low employment these facilities generate. Indian States, many already under fiscal pressure, will face similar arithmetic.

So far, this looks like an infrastructure story. But the deeper issue is where value accumulates.

When global firms operate large AI systems in India, India supplies electricity, water, land, grid stability, and regulatory certainty. What it does not automatically gain is control over the intelligence being produced. The models, systems, and optimisation logic remain proprietary and mobile. The infrastructure stays. The intelligence can leave.

This imbalance does not show up clearly in GDP numbers. India could host vast amounts of AI activity while capturing only a thin slice of its strategic value. India has seen this pattern before. The telecom revolution delivered cheap connectivity at scale, but platform power — data control and pricing leverage — consolidated elsewhere. India became essential to global platforms without owning them.

AI infrastructure risks repeating this mistake at a deeper level. This time, the subsidy is not just market access. It is power, water, land, and grid stability.

There is also a strategic dimension. Large computing clusters are inherently dual-use. The same systems that power commercial applications can also be used for surveillance, cyber operations, or influence campaigns. Countries responding seriously are not rejecting AI infrastructure; they are setting conditions around transparency, oversight, and national capability building.

SET THE TERMS

India still has an advantage others lack: time. The US and Ireland learned these lessons after leverage was lost. India can still define the terms — before scale makes those choices irreversible.

India does not need to slow its ambitions, but it must price them honestly. Large data centres should be treated as strategic infrastructure, not routine real estate. Power and water costs must be transparent and capped, incentives time-bound, and public subsidies tied to domestic capability, not permanent concessions. Most of all, hosting computation must come with ownership of skills, systems, and models.

These safeguards do not block growth. They decide who benefits from it. Set the terms early, and infrastructure builds national strength. Delay them, and the costs will still arrive — quietly, and without leverage.

The writer is a Physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill, US

Social media ban for minors, a nuanced issue

Thanks to the smartphone, children in poor families play a key role in ensuring access to education and public services

Aparajita Bharti

Lately, there’s is clear shift in the narrative in India with respect to social media regulation and children. State after State is signalling the need for a social media ban for under-16s. The Chief Economic Advisor’s framing of digital addiction as a public health issue has added momentum to this conversation. However, there’s need to take a more considered approach before this snowballs into a politically emotive issue as it did in the West.

First, access to internet in India is directly linked with social mobility, especially in low income and rural areas. Children are in fact “chief technical officers” of their households, often helping their families navigate the internet including accessing government services which are increasingly going online. The survey in ASER 2024, which has been quoted by the Economic Survey, while noting the high social media usage among young people, has also noted that more than half of them use smartphone for education, as they lack access to resources that urban children have.

This data clearly show the inverse dependence of mothers on their children for digital guidance. Many State governments have been distributing phones/tablets especially to students in grades 10 and 12, as they recognise the link between economic mobility and education opportunities not just for them, but their entire families.

Second, in many Western countries, phones were allowed in schools which led to different outcomes such as social connections, campus bullying, mental health issues, etc. Here in India, from the very beginning, most schools did not allow phones. The Indian instinct to follow the middle path should not be discounted. India has a high percentage of shared device usage (around 70 per cent according to some surveys in low-income and rural households). This leads to higher supervision by parents organically and control on on-screen time. A ban, therefore, will not achieve much as children will continue to access platforms through the shared household phones.

Third and most important, curbing social media alone will not take care of all online harms. In a recent YLAC Screen survey, children expressed a higher degree of concern with unwanted



ONLINE SAFETY. Banning social media alone won’t do K BHAGYA PRAKASH

contacts on gaming platforms and gaming culture. Also, AI related harm to children was detected. There’s, therefore, a need to make the entire internet safe for children, of which social media is but one platform.

The narrative around bans is no doubt stemming from parents’ concern, considering the amount of time children are spending online. Millennial parents are grappling with the onerous task of limiting their children’s time with phones. Fortunately, the Digital Personal Data Protection Act 2023 will be implemented in India next year and it has already made way for verified parental consent. The Act has also

banned targeted advertising and limited the scope for personalisation for children.

Further, the tech industry cannot also afford to have its head in the sand anymore. There is a real need to discuss a middle path solution with intellectual honesty and rigour. It is not enough for the tech industry to introduce product features for safer teen experience and parental controls; there is a need to drive their uptake on their platforms. Further, safety-by-design principles should not apply only to social media, but all platforms that children are more likely to access including gaming and AI chatbots. There are many in-between regulatory approaches that can be adopted by industry, policymakers and civil society.

India is uniquely positioned to offer an alternative pathway on online child safety — one that balances their access and well-being since this is an economic imperative for us. The internet has been transformative for children and their families who do not have equal opportunities.

The writer is Founding Partner of The Quantum Hub and Co-Founder of Young Leaders for Active Citizenship

LETTERS TO EDITOR

Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Rights over spectrum

This refers to ‘Spectrum redefined’ (February 20). The Supreme Court’s conclusion that spectrum is not an asset of the corporate debtor capable of restructuring under IBC is a welcome judgment. This landmark ruling clarifies the constitutional status of spectrum and significantly limits the reach of the IBC in sectors involving natural resources. It preserves the sovereign regulatory control over telecom licences. This judgment will ensure that statutory

dues linked to natural resource allocation cannot be diluted through insolvency resolution. This ruling is a major setback for financial creditors such as Aircel which sought to monetise spectrum rights to recover loans.

Bal Govind

Noida

The spin-offs of freebies

This refers to ‘Freebies, and their many hazards’ (February 20). It has become fashionable to label every

welfare measure in Tamil Nadu as a “freebie”. In a consumption driven State, money placed directly in the hands of women and lower income families does not vanish, but circulates. It supports small traders and local MSMEs. This is not reckless spending, rather a calibrated demand support. More importantly, governance is not merely about balancing books, it is also about balancing society. Inclusive policies that bring women and vulnerable communities into the economic

mainstream strengthen both dignity and productivity. Tamil Nadu’s steady industrial and revenue performance suggests that social justice and economic growth are not contradictions, but complements.

Leo H

Tirunelveli, TN

Ethical banking

Apropos ‘Ethics in banking is not just about compliance’ (February 20), in the digital era, both system driven ethics and individual ethics influence

institutional ethics. While system driven ethics is centralised and catalysed by several policies, individual ethics plays a greater role in winning the confidence and trust of customers. Frontline staff should understand the necessity and urgency of customers’ requests and address the same in a timely manner. A patient listening and polite response would do wonders in winning over customers.

RV Baskaran

Pune

QUICKLY.

JSW Infra to issue shares to meet min stake norm



Mumbai: Port operator JSW Infrastructure said it has approved raising equity capital by issuing up to 25 crore shares, setting the stage for a fresh fund infusion to back its aggressive expansion plans and to comply with regulatory norms for minimum public stake. The company did not specify how much of funds it planned to raise but based on its closing market price on Friday, the share issuance is worth ₹6,325 crore. The proposed issuance will help the company meet SEBI's requirement to raise public shareholding to 25 per cent within three years of listing. The port operator debuted on the bourses on October 3, 2023. The fund-raise comes as the company is executing a ₹39,000-crore integrated capital expenditure programme aimed at scaling port capacity from 177 million tonnes per annum (MTPA) to 400 MTPA by FY30. The plan spans brownfield expansions, new connectivity projects and greenfield developments across Odisha, Karnataka, Maharashtra and Oman.

OUR BUREAU

Corporate bond issuances drop 6% in 9 months of FY26

C-D RATIO. Bank loans surged across segments y-o-y, with credit outpacing deposit

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Total corporate bond issuances in the first nine months of the current financial year (9MFY26) are about 6 per cent lower at ₹6.83 lakh crore, against ₹7.25 lakh crore in the corresponding period of the previous year. This development comes amidst rising corporate bond yields and the shift towards bank credit.

Corporate bond issuances increased to ₹74,000 crore in December 2025 from ₹59,000 crore in November 2025, according to the RBI's 'State of the Economy' report.

Corporate bond yields hardened across tenors and the rating spectrum, with their spreads over corresponding maturity government securities generally widening.

For example, in the case of one-year and three-year 'AAA'-rated corporate bonds, their spreads over corresponding maturity government securities widened to 181 basis points (bps) during the January 16, 2026-February 16, 2026 period



SOME RESPITE. Corporate bond issuances increased to ₹74,000 crore in December 2025 from ₹59,000 crore in November 2025, per the RBI's 'State of the Economy' report

(from 151 bps during the December 16, 2025-January 14, 2026 period) and 91 bps (80 bps) respectively.

CREDIT AND DEPOSIT Scheduled commercial banks' (SCBs) credit and deposit growth continued to be in double digits during the month, with credit growth outpacing deposit growth, per the bulletin.

SCBs' credit growth increased marginally to 14.6 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) as on January 31, 2026, from 14.5 per cent (y-o-y) as on December 31, 2025. Their deposit growth declined

marginally to 12.5 per cent (y-o-y) from 12.7 per cent (y-o-y) during the same period last year.

Overall, non-food bank credit growth (y-o-y) witnessed strengthening across all major sectors in December, 2025.

Agriculture and industrial credit growth surged to double digits. Within industries, lending to micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) as well as large industries witnessed higher growth.

Credit to services sector grew, due to a steep rise in bank lending to NBFCs,

SCBs' credit and deposit growth continued to be in double digits during the month, with credit growth outpacing deposit growth, per the RBI bulletin

along with robust growth in sectors like trade and commercial real estate. Housing, gold and vehicle loan segments drove growth of personal loans.

FINANCIAL RESOURCES So far in FY26 (up to January 31, 2026), the total flow of financial resources to the commercial sector increased to ₹34.5 lakh crore from ₹25.5 lakh crore a year ago. Non-bank sources — corporate bond issuances, and foreign direct investment to India — has shown a marked increase so far.

As on January 31, 2026, the total outstanding credit to the commercial sector rose by 14.7 per cent, with non-bank sources registering a growth of 15.1 per cent.

Near-term outlook for economy remains favourable, says RBI

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The near-term outlook for the economy remains favourable and is well-positioned to sustain its high growth momentum, driven by consumption, investment, and productivity-enhancing reforms, said RBI staffers in the latest monthly bulletin.

The Monetary Policy Committee's (MPC) resolution on February 6, 2026, revised upward the growth projections for Q1 (April-June) FY27 and Q2 (July-September) by 0.2 per cent each, to 6.9 per cent and 7 per cent, respectively. Inflation is expected to remain benign and near the inflation target, providing a positive growth inflation balance in the near term, the staffers said in the article 'State of the Economy' published in the RBI's February 2026 monthly bulletin.

TRADE AGREEMENTS The MPC resolution earlier in February projected the CPI inflation for FY26 at 2.1 per cent, with Q4 (January-March) at 3.2 per cent. CPI inflation for Q1 and Q2 FY27 are now projected at 4 and 4.2 per cent, respectively. The staffers noted that the completion of the India-EU



RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra

free trade negotiations in January-end and the subsequent interim trade agreement between India and the US are likely to play a significant role in the coming years by improving market access, enhancing export competitiveness, and integrating Indian firms more deeply into global value chains.

"In the immediate term, it has led to a change in investor sentiments. Foreign portfolio investment (FPI) into equity and debt segment staged a comeback in February," they said.

In February so far (up to 16th), net FPI recorded inflows amounting to \$2.3 billion.

With the aforementioned agreements in place, the labour-intensive sectors and export-oriented industries

Inflation is expected to stay benign and near the inflation target, providing a positive growth inflation balance in the near term, according to the 'State of the Economy' report

in India are expected to receive a major support.

HEADLINE INFLATION The staffers noted that headline inflation continues to remain benign, as per the first print under the revised CPI series. Based on the CPI 2024 base year series, headline inflation (as per the provisional data released by the National Statistics Office on February 12, 2026) stood at 2.8 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) in January. CPI food, fuel and core (CPI excluding food and fuel) inflation inflation were 2.1 per cent, 0.4 per cent and 3.4 per cent, respectively.

Excluding precious metals, core inflation was lower at 1.9 per cent, indicating that underlying price pressures remain relatively contained, the staffers said.

'Central banks worldwide to follow divergent paths while approaching end of easing cycle'

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Inflation outcomes are likely to remain divergent across countries and Central banks globally could have dissimilar policy paths while approaching the end of their easing cycles, Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Governor Sanjay Malhotra said during the latest monetary policy committee (MPC) held earlier this month, according to the minutes of the meeting released by the RBI on Friday.

In the backdrop of a large fiscal stimulus and geopolitical uncertainty, global investor sentiments are nervous and financial markets remain volatile, he said.

In the Indian context, economic activity, driven primarily by domestic factors, has remained resilient with real GDP growth in 2025-26 projected to be higher by 90 basis points (bps) from 6.5 per cent in 2024-25, and the outlook for the ensuing year is also expected to be strong, he said.

"Inflation in November

and December 2025 continued to remain low and below the lower tolerance threshold. In terms of the overall trajectory, inflation is expected to remain benign. Headline inflation is projected at 2.1 per cent for 2025-26. The revised outlook for inflation, with headline CPI inflation in Q1 2026-27 and Q2 at 4 per cent and 4.2 per cent, respectively, is also near the inflation target," Malhotra said.

EXTERNAL SOURCES "Excluding precious metals, inflation outlook is even lower. Precious metals contribute about 60-70 basis points to inflation," he added, voting to maintain repo rate at 5.25 per cent and continuing with neutral stance.

RBI Deputy Governor Poonam Gupta also voted for leaving the repo rate unchanged and maintaining a neutral stance. As of now, the risk to inflation from external sources (e.g. oil prices, commodity prices, or pass through of the exchange rate depreciation) is perceived to be limited as well.



Inflation is likely to remain benign across sectors

Further, having already lowered the policy rate by a cumulative 125 bps in four of the last six meetings, another rate cut does not seem warranted, she said.

External MPC member Nagesh Kumar commended Indian exporters for diversifying to other markets with government support during trade tensions with the US.

DIFFERING VIEW External member Ram Singh voted for leaving the repo unchanged, but was the sole member to vote for changing the stance to accommodative from neutral.

"In view of the reduced

volatility underlying headline CPI and the dormancy of the CPI core (excluding gold and silver), it cannot be the end of the current easing cycle. Moreover, the convergence of internal price stability, robust economic fundamentals, and developments on the trade and investment fronts has created a rare window for monetary policy, in which remaining 'neutral' is not appropriate at a moment that demands a proactive signal to the economy," he said.

"The exact quantum and timing of further rate cut will depend on incoming data, but a growth-supporting stance is very much consistent with a stable inflation outlook. Moreover, given the stable inflation and fiscal outlooks, a change in stance to 'accommodative' will facilitate transmission of the rate cuts so far by putting downward pressure on market rates, yields for sovereign and corporate bonds and the rate spread between the two. I vote for a status quo in policy rate and am in favour of the stance being 'accommodative'," he added.

'SBI can provide ₹94,000 cr for acquisition financing'

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The State Bank of India (SBI) can provide acquisition financing support of up to ₹94,000 crore to India Inc, going by the RBI's Amendment Directions for Commercial Banks on Credit Facilities, according to Chairman CS Setty.

As per the directions, banks can provide acquisition financing to Indian companies — listed and unlisted — of up to 20 per cent of their tier-1 capital. Total bank financing cannot exceed 75 per cent of the acquisition value.

Speaking to reporters on the sidelines of the Indian Banks' Association's 78th annual general meeting, Setty said initially, the SBI will tread the acquisition financing space in a calibrated manner, beginning with listed companies. The bank will be taking up the standard operating procedures to the Board for its approval.

OVERSEAS EXPANSION Further, SBI is in talks with Japanese banks to jointly bankroll acquisition financing.



CS Setty, Chairperson, State Bank of India

Banks have put in place a Board-approved policy on acquisition finance, suitably incorporating the underwriting benchmarks that address the structural complexities of such transactions, in particular relating to exposure limits, equity contribution, leverage multiples, and cash-flow certainty.

According to SBI's Economic Research Department, M&A deals in FY24 were valued at over \$120 billion (₹10 lakh crore).

Assuming debt component of 40 per cent of M&A and 30 per cent of this could be financed by banks, this translates into a potential credit growth of ₹1.2 lakh crore.

'Banks should give loans to small biz at cheaper rates'

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Department of Financial Services Secretary Nagaraju M on Friday exhorted banks to give loans to small businesses and the self-employed at cheaper interest rates as they are backed by credit guarantees from government institutions.

He noted that banks chase corporates, offering loans at 7-8 per cent. But the loan offers are declined.

"We keep asking whether they (corporates) require money. They are declining (offers). But those who want, we lend at maybe around 7 per cent," Nagaraju said in his speech at IBA's 78th AGM. "Let's say, a maid-servant, a rickshaw-puller, driver... they are the people who require loans. And we lend at between 9 and 11 per cent... And NBFCs, they lend to them at a little more than 20 per cent," he said. "Can we do something? For small business loans, we have institutions that guarantee (the loans). So, can we reduce the borrowing cost for these borrowers?"

Nagaraju observed that India's financial system is



M Nagaraju, Secretary, Department of Financial Services

still largely bank dominated. But bank credit-to-GDP ratio stands at just 57 per cent. This is significantly lower than economies such as China, which has 199 per cent credit-to-GDP ratio, the US at 147 per cent and Japan at 153 per cent.

FOR VIKSIT BHARAT "Clearly, there is a vast gap that we must bridge as we look ahead to Viksit Bharat 2047, as we aim for a nominal GDP to grow to \$30 trillion from \$3.7 trillion now. We envisage a per capita income of \$18,000-20,000 compared to \$2,800... To meet aspirations of 2047, total credit to private non-financial sector must be expanded to at least 130 per cent," he said.

Invesco Mutual Fund

Invesco Asset Management (India) Pvt. Ltd.
(CIN: U67190MH2005PTC153471), 2101-A, 21st Floor, A Wing, Marathon Futurex, N. M. Joshi Marg, Lower Parel, Mumbai - 400 013

Telephone: +91 22 6731 0000, Email: mfservices@invescoindia.com; www.invescomutualfund.com

NOTICE CUM ADDENDUM

Addendum to Statement of Additional Information of Invesco Mutual Fund

The investors / unitholders are requested to take note of following changes to Statement of Additional Information ("SAI") of Invesco Mutual Fund ("the Fund").

Appointment of Director:

Mr. Munesh Khanna has been appointed as an Associate Director on the Board of Invesco Asset Management (India) Pvt. Ltd. ('**IAMI**') with effect from **Tuesday, February 17, 2026**. Accordingly, the following details of Mr. Munesh Khanna shall be included in SAI of the Fund:

Name	Age / Educational Qualification	Brief Experience
Mr. Munesh Khanna (Associate Director)	63 Years B.Com., C.A.	Mr. Munesh Khanna has more than 3 decades of experience in the corporate advisory and financial services domain and built wealth of experience in corporate finance, restructuring, and strategic decision making through his involvement in numerous significant transactions spanning various industries. He specializes in providing strategic advice to corporates, businesses, owners and senior managers for enhancing the value of their businesses through initiatives such as raising resources from Capital Markets and Private Equity, Mergers & Acquisitions, divestitures and corporate restructuring. He has worked closely, both with large conglomerates and mid-sized companies as well as with start-ups. His extensive industry experience and knowledge spans across Infrastructure, Energy, Telecom, Airline and Airports, Entertainment and Media, Pharma, Healthcare, Financial Services, Payments, and Fintech. He has worked with Arthur Anderson India Pvt. Ltd. for 17 years starting as tax analyst and ultimately was Country Head of it's Financial Consulting Practice. He also held leadership position for Indian operations of N.M. Rothschild & Sons Pvt. Ltd. from 2001 till 2007, turning it around into a global M&A house in India. At PricewaterhouseCoopers LLP, he was the Corporate Finance & Business Restructuring Leader, primarily responsible for leading two verticals and also playing a key role for go-to-market efforts for the western region. He also worked as a partner at Halycon Resources & Management Pvt. Ltd., an entity that identified and invested in opportunities involving high level of management involvement. Currently, he runs his own corporate & strategic advisory and investment banking firm, Backbay Advisors Pvt. Ltd. and also a partner at Brunswick Corporate Communications LLP, a global communication firm. He has also served and advised as a member of the Boards of various renowned listed and unlisted Companies for over two decades which includes, inter-alia, Hinduja Global Solutions Ltd., Gulf Oil Lubricants India Ltd., JSW Energy Ltd., JM Financial Products Ltd. and JM Financial Asset Reconstruction Company Ltd., Black Box Ltd., Finolex Industries Ltd., Arvind Group, Indofil Organic Ltd., etc. He is also serving as a trustee for the Nanavati Charitable Trust Hospital, one of Mumbai's largest hospitals. He is currently the Chairman of JM Financial Services Asset Reconstruction Company Ltd., and his role is to oversee the governance and compliance of ARC from a Board perspective. He is also a member of various committees for the resolution and settlement of debts acquired. He is well versed with RBI and SEBI regulations relating to financial products.

All other terms & conditions of the SAI of the Fund will remain unchanged.

This notice cum addendum forms an integral part of the Statement of Additional Information of Invesco Mutual Fund as amended from time to time.

For Invesco Asset Management (India) Pvt. Ltd. (Investment Manager for Invesco Mutual Fund)

Sd/-

Saurabh Nanavati

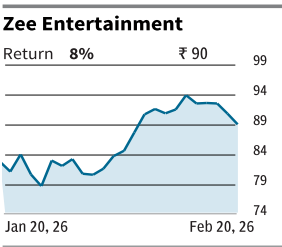
Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer

Date: February 20, 2026

Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

QUICKLY.

SEBI sends show-cause notice to Zee



Mumbai: Zee Entertainment has received a show-cause notice from SEBI regarding an ongoing 2019 case alleging fund diversion and governance lapses that derailed Zee's planned merger with Sony Pictures Networks India. The company said it will file an appropriate reply to SEBI and added the prolonged investigation over the years had hurt its strategic moves. "This investigation has derailed certain strategic steps planned by the company, including the proposed merger, causing immense loss to the company's shareholders," Zee said in a response. Zee had contested SEBI's interim order relating to the allegations at the Securities Appellate Tribunal but the same was quashed. OUR BUREAU

LIC MF's Pocket SIP accounts hit 1.80 lakh

Mumbai: LIC Mutual Fund has opened 1.80 lakh Pocket SIP to democratise mutual fund investment and widen the coverage in smaller cities. The fund house facilitates minimum daily and weekly SIP of ₹100 and ₹150, while monthly SIP can start from ₹200. The minimum quarterly investment is fixed at ₹1,000. Ravi Kumar Jha, MD and CEO, LIC Mutual Fund, said the response for Pocket SIP had been tremendous, with investors keen to participate in India's growth story and growing financial literacy. The cost of processing Pocket SIP has been on the higher side, but LIC MF is willing to take the extra cost for the benefit of reaching the common man, he said. OUR BUREAU

BROKER'S CALL.

Citigroup

AADHAR HOUSING (BUY)
Target: ₹650
CMP: ₹479.40
We hosted MD & CEO, CFO of Aadhar Housing for investor meetings in Mumbai. Key takeaways: Medium-term AUM trajectory of 20-22 per cent with over ₹50,000 crore milestone within 3 years. Pan-India presence and deeper coverage de-risk it from State-specific growth challenges; Dual market approach to effectively manage market dynamics - Urban/Emerging 'A' markets target volume/AUM growth, while 'B' & 'C' prioritise value and enhanced risk-adjusted returns; spreads to sustain above 5.6 per cent over the medium term; and credit cost guidance of 25-27 bps; Annual improvement of 40-50 bps in C/I and 6-8 bps in cost/assets over the next 3 years. We rate Aadhar Housing shares as Buy. We expect Aadhar shares to command a premium, given superior and projected sustainable RoA/RoE of over 4.5/16.5 per cent over FY25-27E. Aadhar differentiates itself with: scale with granularity; non-conventional diversified distribution; cost-efficient graded branch structure, phased expansion and tech stack improving productivity & analytics. Using a two-stage Gordon Growth model, we arrive at a target price of ₹650 for Aadhar assuming CoEs of 12.2 per cent, medium-term RoEs of 16 per cent and high growth phase of 10 years with expected growth of 20 per cent. We assign price-to-book of 3.3x 9MFY27E BV. **Risks:** The build-up of stress in LAP over and above expectations; and roll-back from elevated GS3 getting disrupted due to activity slowdown also leading to growth slowdown.

Geojit Investments

TIMKEN INDIA (ACCUMULATE)
Target: ₹3,665
CMP: ₹3,154.05
Timken India manufactures and distributes anti-friction bearings, components and mechanical power transmission products. It also offers maintenance, refurbishment, and industrial services across various sectors. Timken's Q3-FY26 revenue from operations grew 14 per cent y-o-y to ₹764.3 crore. All business segments grew during the quarter, with the Process segment showing the strongest momentum, jumping 24 per cent y-o-y to ₹167 crore. Though impacted by temporary cost pressures and the initial ramp-up phase of the Bharuch plant, Timken continues to demonstrate underlying demand strength across key industrial segments. We expect revenues to grow at 15 per cent CAGR, driven by demand improvement from CV and rail segments and improving utilisation at the new SRB/CRB capacity and potential upside from favourable global trade developments that enhance export opportunities. Margins are expected to expand from 17.8 per cent in FY26E to 19.9 per cent in FY28E as mix normalises from current unfavourable mix and Bharuch ramp-up costs taper off and operating leverage improves with rising domestic and export volumes. Resultantly, earnings are projected to grow at a strong 22 per cent CAGR over FY26-28E, reflecting both topline momentum and margin recovery. Hence, we value the stock at 44X on FY28 EPS and upgrade the stock from Sell to Accumulate rating with a Target price of ₹3,665/Share.

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Ambit sees accounting stress for EMS firms

COST HEADWINDS. Rising memory chip prices to put pressure on Keynes, says global brokerage CLSA

Madhu Balaji
Bengaluru

The electronics manufacturing services (EMS) sector is showing signs of deteriorating accounting quality and weak cash generation despite strong reported earnings growth, according to a report by Ambit Capital. The study found a widening disconnect between profitability and cash flows, with rising working capital needs and aggressive capital expenditure leading to negative cumulative free cash flows across most companies, raising concerns about the sustainability of expansion.

Some of the key players in the segment are Dixon Technologies, Amber Enterprises, Keynes Technologies, PG Electroplast, Avalon Technologies and Syрма SGS.

Nuvama Institutional Equities recently noted that the majority of EMS firms

posted improved margins year-on-year (y-o-y) in Q3FY26. The sectoral revenue, EBITDA and PAT grew 13 per cent, 31 per cent and 39 per cent respectively, it added.

Global brokerage CLSA flagged rising risks for the EMS sector amid surging memory chip prices. It said the global memory industry is entering an early boom phase across DRAM, NAND and specialty memory, driven by AI-led demand and constrained supply growth from manufacturers.

CASH CRUNCH

Ambit Capital's report highlighted that accounting quality across EMS companies had weakened in recent years as cash conversion deteriorated and working capital cycles lengthened.

While revenue growth has been buoyed by structural manufacturing tailwinds and supply-chain diversification,



SHORT CIRCUIT. Cash conversion deteriorated and working capital cycles lengthened for electronic manufacturers, said Ambit Capital in a report. BLOOMBERG

higher inventory, receivables, and capital deployment have strained operational liquidity.

KAYNES OUTLOOK

Among individual companies, Keynes Technology drew the highest scrutiny on earnings quality, per Ambit Capital. The report noted negative pre-tax operating cash flow relative to EBITDA and rising working capital intensity driven by higher receiv-

ables and inventory days.

Keynes lags due to lower accounting score, low ID score (0), promoter presence in audit committee, auditor appointment practices, low audit fees and notable KMP churn, the report read.

While management initiatives such as bill discounting and supply chain financing are expected to improve collections, Ambit Capital stressed that cash conversion remains a key metric.

SEBI looking at reshuffling of various advisory committees' members

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

SEBI has started the process of reshuffling members of several of its industry and expert advisory committees, according to people familiar with the development. The exercise has begun with the Commodity Derivatives Advisory Committee (CDAC), for which invitations have already been sent to potential new members.

The reconstitution of other committees is expected to follow in phases, with each panel being taken up sequentially over a period of one to two weeks. Sources said the over-

all exercise is likely to be completed by the end of March.

CDAC advises the regulator on matters related to the commodity derivatives market, including contract design, delivery and settlement mechanisms, warehousing norms and market development. SEBI has revamped CDAC, replacing some of its members.

"The regulator is taking up one committee at a time. The process has started with CDAC, and invitations have gone out," one person said.

SEBI is expected to take up the reconstitution of several other advisory committees, including the Secondary Market Advisory Committee,

Markets edge up in volatile day after Thursday's big rout

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Equities recovered from early weakness to close higher on Friday but market breadth remained negative, underscoring a cautious undertone despite index gains.

The Sensex rose 316.57 points to close at 82,814.71 after opening at 82,272.49 against a previous close of 82,498.14. During the day, it hit a high of 83,132.08 and a low of 82,206.21. The Nifty50 advanced 116.90 points to 25,571.25 after a weak start. Buying in heavy-weight cyclical helped the benchmarks rebound sharply from intraday lows before momentum eased in the afternoon session.

Among Nifty 50 constituents, Hindalco Industries gained 3.21 per cent, NTPC rose 2.64 per cent and L&T climbed 2.33 per cent. SBI Life Insurance added 1.81 per cent while HUL ad-

vanced 1.71 per cent. On the losing side, Kwality Wall's fell 3.46 per cent, Eternal declined 1.31 per cent, Infosys dropped 1.28 per cent, Tech Mahindra slipped 1.03 per cent and Grasim lost 1.02 per cent.

Sectorally, PSU banks, metals, power and capital goods led gains, while IT and media stocks ended in the red.

Broader markets were mixed, with the Nifty Midcap 100 rising 0.48 per cent and the Smallcap 100 declining 0.11 per cent. Market breadth was weak as 1,882 stocks advanced against 2,303 declines on the BSE, with 204 stocks hitting 52-week lows compared with 82 at highs.

Ajit Mishra of Religare Broking Ltd said, "Markets traded with volatility... improved buying in heavy-weight cyclical helped indices recover as participants accumulated quality names after recent weakness."



which advises on issues related to trading, surveillance and secondary market structure; the Primary Market Advisory Committee; and the Market Data Advisory Committee. The reshuffle may also cover the Intermediary Advisory Committee, the Alternative Investment Policy Advis-

ory Committee, the FPI Advisory Committee, the Social Stock Exchange Advisory Committee, the Hybrid Securities Advisory Committee, the Technical Advisory Committee, the Advisory Committee on Mutual Funds, the ESG Advisory Committee and the Advisory Committee for SEBI Investor Protection and Education Fund.

Upcoming meetings may be scheduled only after the reshuffle, said another source.

Most SEBI consultation papers go through these industry committees to iron out the proposals before being put out for public consultation. SEBI did not respond to queries sent for comment.

Innovation is fine but not at cost of market integrity: SEBI chief

Asian News International
Mumbai

SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey on Friday reiterated the regulator's philosophy of "optimum regulation," balancing innovation with market integrity and investor protection. He warned that cyber fraud is likely to increase with digital adoption and urged investors to remain vigilant, particularly safeguarding senior citizens.

"We are guided by the philosophy of optimum regulation. We want the innovation and market development to flourish, but not at the cost of market integrity or your protection. Cyber fraud will continue to increase as digital channels become more influential. We will continue our relentless efforts to combat these

frauds through technology, tightening processes, and spreading awareness," Pandey said.

Addressing Outlook Money's 40After40 event, the SEBI chief underscored that trust remains the cornerstone of India's rapidly expanding capital markets, cautioning that rising retail participation must be supported by stronger investor protection, transparency and financial education.

Pandey emphasised that financial security is a lifelong journey involving wealth creation, inflation protection and steady post-retirement income. He said capital markets offer long-term diversification opportunities but warned investors against relying on unsolicited offers or "guaranteed return" messages circulating on social media.

PSU stocks will be back in focus as privatisation gathers steam

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The government's plan to raise ₹80,000 crore through disinvestment and asset monetisation in the next fiscal has stoked fresh investor interest in public sector company stocks and boosted equity markets emerging from prolonged volatility driven by geopolitical and trade tariffs. The historical performance of public sector undertakings (PSUs) following disinvestment underscores the value-creation potential of such reforms.

Industry bodies have backed the push, with CII Director-General Chandrajit Banerjee calling for a three-year rolling privatisation roadmap with phased stake

reductions. Strategic disinvestments have led to sharper operational focus, improved capital allocation and stronger market discipline.

Vineet Bolinjkar, Head of Research at Ventura Securities, said the government's disinvestment track record demonstrates its ability to unlock value. Post-disinvestment performance under private ownership typically shows improved operating metrics, stronger return ratios and greater capital discipline compared with the public-sector structure.

DIVESTMENT MOVE

Hindustan Zinc has delivered significant returns since its disinvestment in 2002, with market capitalisation rising from ₹237 crore to over ₹2.5 lakh crore by 2026.

Anil Agarwal, Chairman of Vedanta, recently noted that the company was once seen as outdated and inefficient. Today, Hindustan Zinc accounts for nearly 75 per cent of India's zinc production and has emerged as a major silver producer. Last year, it contributed nearly ₹20,000 crore to the exchequer, including ₹3,600 crore in dividend to the government.

The privatisation of VSNL in 2002 and its transformation into Tata Communications turned a state monopoly into a global enterprise serving customers in 190 countries. The government also realised ₹348 crore from the sale of its stake in CMC Ltd, which was later acquired by the Tata Group and merged with Tata Consultancy Services.

Silver, gold ETFs and SEBI's measured framework

RINGSIDE VIEW.



KS BADRI NARAYANAN

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), in a consultation paper, has proposed introducing price bands for exchange-traded funds (ETFs), particularly those focusing on gold and silver ETFs.

The regulator put forward these measures in response to sharp fluctuations in global precious metal prices, driven by ongoing macroeconomic uncertainty and geopolitical tensions. These factors have significantly affected silver ETFs, with some witnessing single-day price declines of more than 20 per cent a few days ago, resulting in heightened volatility in both performance and investor valuations.

ETFs, based on equity or debt indices, are market-linked securities traded on stock exchanges. Like MFs, they collect money from investors and invest in ETFs which, in turn, buy index constituents through basket

buying, with same weightage of the underlying index. The ETFs can be bought through direct (based on NAV price from MFs) or exchanges (where they trade like equity).

For gold and Silver ETFs, the underlying is the precious metals. For each ETF investor, the AMC will buy the silver or gold and keep it in vaults with a designated custodian appointed by the fund house.

SEBI'S RATIONALE

SEBI observed that sudden sharp increases or decreases in global gold and silver prices could significantly disrupt trading in domestic ETFs. These extreme price movements are often fuelled more by speculative activity than by actual underlying fundamentals. To promote market stability and reduce the risk of panic-driven selling or buying, SEBI proposed the introduction of a calibrated circuit breaker mechanism.

SEBI proposed an initial price band of 6 per cent, either upward or downward, for gold and silver ETFs.

If the 6 per cent threshold



CHECKING RISK. SEBI has proposed the introduction of a calibrated circuit breaker mechanism for ETFs. ISTOCKPHOTO

is breached, trading will be suspended for 15 minutes.

The cooling-off period, according to SEBI, allows investors to reassess information and prevents panic-driven trades. After the cooling-off period, the price band may be expanded in increments of 3 per cent, subject to strict monitoring conditions.

If international gold or silver prices move beyond the domestic daily threshold of 9 per cent, the exchanges may relax limits in stages of 3 per cent, with a mandatory cooling-off period each time. Nevertheless, under no circumstances can the price of gold or silver ETFs move bey-

ond 20 per cent in a single trading day.

STRINGENT CRITERIA

Further, to prevent misuse of price flexibility, SEBI also proposed stringent trading criteria before allowing further relaxation beyond certain thresholds: At least 50 trades, involving 10 unique client codes, participation of three trading members on both buy and sell sides and the price band may only be flexed twice in a single trading day, ensuring tight regulatory control.

SEBI also proposed applying a similar graded price band framework to debt and equity index ETFs.

Nifty 50 Movers

	Close(f)	Pts	PE	WN(%)
L&T	4380.60	25.78	31.75	4.41
Reliance Ind	1419.40	14.66	19.64	8.22
NTPC	372.95	10.14	14.57	1.52
Hindalco	935.70	9.54	13.08	1.16
State Bank	1216.10	9.46	12.97	4.33
ICICI Bank	1394.50	8.93	17.61	8.54
Kotak Bank	421.35	7.98	22.29	2.66
Bajaj Finance	1030.20	7.66	34.98	2.35
Ais Bank	1368.30	7.35	16.08	3.36
Hind Unilever	2214.50	6.85	54.08	1.76
Tata Steel	208.36	5.35	28.52	1.48
Bharat Elec	441.15	4.56	54.08	1.36
PowerGrid Corp	298.95	4.27	17.91	1.16
Coal India	423.55	3.69	8.77	0.82
SBI Life	2080.30	3.64	85.02	0.80
TCS	4236.40	3.46	78.91	1.50
Titan	278.65	3.41	7.79	0.93
Bajaj Finserv	2058.50	3.17	17.13	1.01
Asian Paints	2428.10	2.71	59.57	0.94
Sun Pharma	1724.40	2.55	37.77	1.57
Nestleindia	1293.80	2.40	76.05	0.80
Martel Suzuki	14977.00	2.13	31.54	1.69
ITC	327.00	2.11	19.79	2.70
UltraTech Cement	12766.00	2.03	49.09	1.30
IntiGlobeAfr	4854.60	1.96	58.45	0.94
Bajaj Auto	9807.00	1.90	30.83	0.93
TCS	2086.20	1.86	20.38	1.16
JSW Steel	1235.80	1.52	38.91	1.00
Cipla	1341.10	1.51	23.90	0.65
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1059.30	1.41	21.79	1.27
Eicher Motors	7936.50	1.19	40.63	0.94
Trent Ltd.	4091.00	1.12	89.78	0.78
Max Healthcare	1087.90	1.05	74.57	0.69
Tata Motors PV	378.00	1.05	51.40	0.68
Apollo Hosp	7615.50	0.52	58.69	0.67
Adani Enter	2160.80	0.23	17.65	0.48
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	2586.00	0.00	102.38	0.73
Kwality Walls	27.73	0.64	0.02	0.02
Dr Reddys Lab	1280.40	0.25	19.35	0.67
Adani Ports	1511.50	-0.29	27.87	0.90
TataConsumerProduct	1156.20	-0.61	77.75	0.65
Wipro	209.86	-0.85	16.51	0.51
HDFC Life	728.65	-1.06	83.04	0.67
Grasim Ind	3521.00	-2.41	20.35	1.32
Tech Mahindra	1456.90	-3.12	31.09	0.79
HCL Tech	1436.50	-3.22	23.67	1.30
Eternal Ltd.	269.45	-3.62	1125.67	1.66
M&M	3412.80	-3.72	25.11	2.61
Bharti Airtel	1977.40	-6.85	30.43	4.73
HDFC Bank	911.85	-12.52	18.12	1.36
Infosys	1353.20	-13.29	19.59	4.07

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers

	Close(f)	Pts	PE	WN(%)
Hyundai Motor India .	2293.40	48.08	32.18	1.41
Canara Bank	154.15	47.84	7.59	2.24
Tata Power	378.00	45.83	24.12	2.74
Abi India	5987.00	42.89	0.00	1.13
Punjab Natl Bank	129.59	36.10	8.33	1.93
Cg Power & Ind Sol	712.15	32.14	101.09	2.11
Vedanta	682.45	32.07	16.11	5.00
Adani Power .	142.70	26.63	24.36	2.43
Siemens	3206.20	26.28	72.01	1.42
Bank Of Baroda	399.05	25.80	8.14	2.88
Jsw Energy .	493.95	22.30	33.16	1.14
Hindustanaeronautics	4170.00	21.29	31.35	3.42
Godrej Consumer	1205.90	20.88	67.74	2.10
Dif	629.30	16.94	35.18	1.74
Avenuesuper	3866.40	14.27	87.84	2.46
Gail (India)	168.47	12.87	12.87	1.96
Power Finance	412.30	12.71	59.77	1.54
Shree Cement	26510.00	11.84	53.25	1.53
Indian Hotels Co. .	674.95	7.51	44.39	2.56
Hindus Zinc	589.35	6.83	21.10	1.10
Jindal Steel	1217.10	6.73	61.58	1.96
Alfa	873.30	6.03	10.81	0.84
Bosch	5231.00	5.21	37.68	1.32
Torrent Pharma	4241.70	4.80	63.19	1.52
Siemens Energy India .	2774.60	4.48	83.64	1.06
MazdaGoan Dock	2360.20	3.85	39.56	0.77
MacroTech Developers .	1071.15	3.46	31.98	1.30
Indian Railway Finance Corp	111.88	2.68	20.87	0.86
Rural Elec	354.20	2.44	5.41	1.91
Power Finance	412.30	2.40	4.05	1.54
Varun Beverages .	453.85	1.44	50.13	2.68
Icici Lombard Gic	1936.10	0.07	34.43	2.02
Bajaj Holdings	11188.00	0.00	13.89	2.09
Pillidint	1464.90	0.00	64.42	1.97
Ambuja Cements	512.00	-0.27	25.72	1.35
Bajaj Housing Finance .	491.07	-0.18	12.59	1.28
Zyduslisciences	900.75	-1.24	18.03	0.97
Divis Lab	6291.00	-2.48	67.37	3.45
Britannia Ind	6098.50	-3.54	60.79	3.11
Solar Industries	13296.00	-5.41	78.81	1.40
Indian Oilcorp	173.79	-5.72	6.66	2.81
Sarwardmotheresoninternat	129.42	-6.13	37.53	2.48
Adanirenewenergy	968.25	-7.59	85.93	1.28
Bpr	366.50	-7.85	57.16	2.07
CholamandAlaminFin	1669.60	-8.88	20.97	3.05
Adani Energy Solutions .	99.40	-9.87	50.30	1.50
Tvs Motor Corp .	3816.20	-9.79	59.37	3.87
United Spirits .	1379.30	-15.77	58.33	1.76
Ltimitndree .	4889.50	-19.48	30.69	1.96
Info Edge I	1074.80	-22.45	41.36	1.80

QUICKLY.

Crude oil near 6-month high on US-Iran tensions



London: Crude oil prices traded near six-month highs on Friday, poised for their first weekly gain in three weeks on growing concern over potential conflict. Brent crude futures edged down 28 cents to \$71.38 a barrel by 1302 GMT while US WTI crude lost 20 cents to \$66.23. **REUTERS**

Palm oil slips, but still logs weekly gain

Kuala Lumpur: Malaysian palm oil futures closed lower weighed down by weaker soyoil, overproduction concerns and sluggish export demand. The benchmark palm oil contract for May delivery on the Bursa Malaysia Derivatives Exchange slipped 27 ringgit to 4,090 ringgit (\$1,048.72) a tonne. **REUTERS**

Aluminium at 1-week high, copper falters



London: Aluminium prices rose to a one-week high supported by persistent supply concerns, while copper was set for a third weekly loss as inventories keep rising. London Metal Exchange benchmark three-month aluminium rose 0.3 per cent to \$3,078 a tonne. Aluminium has slipped 8 per cent since hitting \$3,356 on January 29. LME copper added 0.1 per cent in official activity to \$12,820. **REUTERS**

AVPL, DeHaat team up to train 1.4 lakh agri and drone entrepreneurs over 5 years

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

AVPL International has announced an association with DeHaat and Farmers City India Pvt Ltd to jointly train approximately 1.4 lakh agri and drone entrepreneurs across India over the next five years. A media statement said the collaboration aimed to establish one of India's largest integrated rural entrepreneurship ecosystems by combining skill development, agri retail expansion, drone technology deployment, electric mobility enablement and structured credit facilitation under a unified framework. **DEPLOYMENT MODEL** AVPL and Farmers City will establish and operate training centres across India, where DeHaat and AVPL will

Investors returned to gold ETFs in 2nd week after booking profits in 1st week

REVIVAL IN INFLOWS. Investors encash \$3.87 b from ETFs in the first week, invest \$2.34 b in second week

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Inflows into physically-backed gold exchange-traded funds returned in the second week of February, after investors booked profits in the first week. However, inflows were lower than outflows. According to data from the World Gold Council (WGC), assets under management (AUM) decreased to \$655 billion in the week ending February 6, compared with \$668.7 billion. However, it increased to \$664.2 billion in the week ending February 13. While investors encashed \$3.87 billion in the first week, they invested \$2.34 billion in the second week. Investments in gold ETFs were in line with the movement of precious metals in the global market. Gold soared to a record high of \$5,608 in the fourth week of

January before paring gains. Investors began to switch from gold to other assets such as bonds after US President Donald Trump nominated Kevin Warsh as the next US Fed chief. **WARSH IMPACT** Gold is currently ruling at \$5,030.77 an ounce, gaining nearly a per cent on Friday following geopolitical tensions over the US-Iran stand-off. Warsh is perceived by the market as hawkish in his stance on interest rates, leading to traders moving out of precious metals, which were seen as the best investment bet till then in view of a falling dollar, tariff wars and geopolitical tensions. Europe, which began to witness outflows from ETFs in January last week (encashing \$942 million), continued to book profits in the first week of this month. The outflow in Europe was \$3.08 billion, but inflows increased to

Rebounding investments									
Region	AUM* (in \$b)		Fund flows (in \$b)		Holdings (tonnes)		Rise in demand (tonnes)		
	Feb 6	Feb 13	Feb 6	Feb 13	Feb 6	Feb 13	Feb 6	Feb 13	Feb 6 Feb 13
N.America	339.3	343.2	-692.6	625.0	2,132.8	2,343.3	-5.8	3.9	
Europe	224.5	227.5	-3,078.0	914.2	1,411.0	1,416.5	-21.2	5.6	
Asia	79.2	81.4	-135.0	841.2	494.9	500.4	-3.8	5.5	
Other	12.0	12.1	34.7	-37.2	75.5	75.4	0.4	-0.1	
Total	655.0	664.2	-3,870.9	2,343.3	4,114.2	4,129.0	-30.4	29.4	

\$914 million in the second week. Outflows and inflows in North America were almost similar, with investors encashing \$692.6 million in the first week and returning to invest \$625 million in the second week. **INDIAN TREND** Gold holdings fell by about 30 tonnes in the first week compared with the week ending January 30 to 4,114.2 tonnes before rising 15 tonnes in the second week. Europe witnessed the biggest fall of 21.2 tonnes, followed by North America at 5.8 tonnes. Though details of the gold ETFs trend in India is limited, provisional data show that AUM dropped from \$19.8 billion in the last week of January to \$18.5 billion. In the second week, there was a marginal rise to \$18.6 billion. Investors in the UK topped encashment in ETFs, taking away \$1.91 billion in the first week, following a \$363 million outflow in the last week of January. In the second week, inflows in the UK were \$272 million. Outflows in the US were

Gold, silver firm up on West Asia tensions

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The precious metal complex gained on Friday with gold topping the key \$5,000 an ounce level and silver crossing \$80 an ounce. In India, gold prices jumped by ₹496 to ₹155,066 per 10 g against ₹154,570 on Thursday on the back of prices firming up trend in the global markets, according to the Indian Bullion and Jewellers Association of India. Silver prices increased by ₹5,552 to ₹2,50,314 per kg against ₹2,44,772 as the ten-

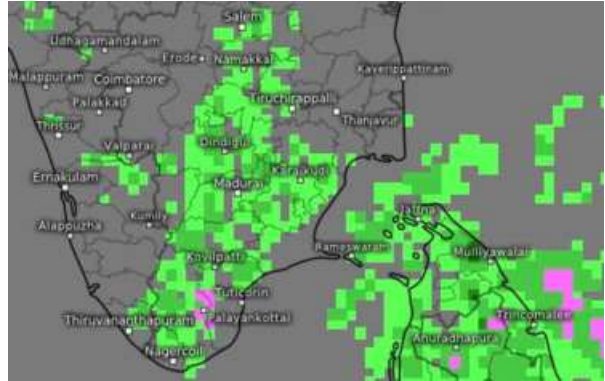
sion between the US and Iran intensified. Kaynat Chainwala, AVP Commodity Research, Kotak Securities, said spot gold extended gains on Friday as escalating geopolitical tensions in the West Asia revived haven demand. **HAVEN DEMAND** Gold prices surged briefly, testing \$5,020 an ounce, then pared gains to drop below \$5,000-mark (and later rebounding to \$5,030), as dollar index climbed to a three-and-a-half-week high of 98.1 after weekly jobless claims fell to 206K and the



Philadelphia Fed Business Outlook jumped to 16.3, both reinforcing signs of economic resilience, said

Chainwala. Markets continue to weigh geopolitical risks against evolving Federal Reserve policy expectations. Investors remain cautious ahead of key economic releases, including PCE inflation, Q4 GDP, and flash PMI data. A softer-than-expected inflation reading could boost expectations for additional rate cuts later this year, supporting bullion prices. Conversely, a hotter inflation print may reinforce higher-for-longer rate expectations, potentially capping further upside in precious metals. **10-DAY WINDOW** Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst-Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities, said gold futures are edging higher as the US-Iran stand-off keeps risk sentiment elevated. However, with the US President Trump reportedly giving Iran a 10-day window for a deal, price action could swing sharply either way over the weekend. Any diplomatic breakthrough in the standoff may trigger profit booking, while escalation could push bullion into another spike, Trivedi added.

Rain alert for TN, Kerala even after causative 'low' weakens



ACTIVE BAY. Rain and thundershowers are seeping in from Sri Lanka to the southern and adjoining central parts of Tamil Nadu
WWW.METEOROLOGIX.COM/IN

Vinson Kurian
Thiruvananthapuram

An existing low-pressure area over the equatorial Indian Ocean and the south-west Bay of Bengal weakened on Friday, leaving behind a remnant circulation that may move northwest towards Sri Lanka by Saturday. Meanwhile, a fresh low pressure area may form over the south-east Bay and the adjoining equatorial Indian Ocean over the next two days. A preparatory cyclonic circulation lay over the equatorial Indian Ocean and adjoining south-east Bay on Friday, reflecting a rare repeat of activity driven mainly by an eastward-moving Madden-Julian Oscillation (MJO) phase bringing enhanced moisture, clouding, rainfall and strong winds. The emerging system may move into the south-central Bay, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) said. It ruled out any significant intensification of the earlier system near the Sri Lanka-Tamil Nadu region.

to develop over the Bay and weaken the system. On Friday, a trough in the upper levels extended from the remnant circulation near Sri Lanka across south Tamil Nadu and south Kerala to Lakshadweep. Heavy rainfall is likely over south Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Mahe on Saturday and Sunday. Isolated to scattered rain, thunderstorms, lightning and gusty winds are likely over Tamil Nadu, Kerala and Mahe. Thunderstorms and lightning are expected over Kerala and Mahe on Monday, over south interior Karnataka for four days from Saturday, and over coastal and north interior Karnataka for three days from Sunday.

RAIN, STORMS IN NORTH A weakening western disturbance persisted as a trough from central Uttar Pradesh to north Gujarat across east Rajasthan. An associated upper-air cyclonic circulation over south Haryana and adjoining Punjab also remained in place. IMD has forecast thunderstorms and lightning over Uttarakhanda on Sunday, Vidarbha on Monday, and Chhattisgarh and Odisha on Monday and Tuesday. Isolated rain/snow is likely over Jammu-Kashmir and Himachal Pradesh on Sunday and Monday, and Uttarakhanda for three days from Sunday.

Specific areas of agri sector merit careful attention in India-US trade deal: SEA

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

The Solvent Extractors' Association of India (SEA) has said that though the India-US bilateral trade agreement is expected to expand market access across a wide spectrum of goods, including agriculture and processed foods, specific areas merit careful attention. In his monthly letter to the members on Friday, Sanjeev Asthana, President of the association, said the agreement is being closely watched by stakeholders, given the scale and scope of the bilateral trade engagement under discussion. Stating that specific areas of edible oil and oilseed ecosystems merit careful attention, he said discussions around biotechnology and genetically modified crops remain a sensitive issue, particularly for soymeal. Enhanced access for US-origin distillers' dried grains with solubles (DDGS) could impact the domestic feed and maize markets. Regulatory caution must be maintained while balancing trade reciprocity. While expanded bilateral trade offers opportunities across sectors, it is essential that agricultural price stability and domestic oilseed competitiveness are safeguarded, he said.



IMPORT THREAT. Enhanced access for US-origin DDGS could impact India's feed and maize markets, according to the SEA

these measures are expected to support productivity gains and expansion beyond traditional growing regions. A key structural initiative is the launch of Bharat VISTAAR, an AI-powered agricultural intelligence platform integrating AgriStack and ICAR data, to enable real-time advisories and data-driven policymaking. However, he noted that reduced allocations under the Remission of Duties and Taxes on Exported Products (RoDTEP) had raised concerns across exporting sectors. The SEA has proposed the inclusion of specific HSN codes — sal-based cocoa butter equivalent, sal stearin, mango butter, kokum butter, and shea stearin, which are products made from minor forest produce — in the ongoing tariff relief dialogue between India and the United Kingdom.

Tea prices rule firm at Kochi sales as demand outpaces supply

V Sajeew Kumar
Kochi

Tea prices at Kochi auctions strengthened this week, with demand continuing to outstrip limited supplies. Premium orthodox leaf grades in Sale 8 gained ₹5-10 a kg, and in some cases up to ₹15, while CTC dust prices remained steady, improving by ₹3-5. Despite the higher levels, market clearance remained robust as quality lots were readily absorbed by domestic blenders and exporters. Anil George, Chairman of the Tea Trade Association of CochIn, attributed the firm trend to lower arrivals, steady domestic consumption and renewed buying interest from CIS and Middle



Eastern markets, particularly for orthodox teas. Strong economic activity in Kerala, aggressive local bidding and a tight supply chain also underpinned prices. The price rise provided much-needed relief to South Indian tea producers, he said. **RISING INPUT COSTS** For growers, he said the price improvement helped offset rising labour and fertilizer costs, provided production

levels remain adequate. If the current demand-supply imbalance persists, prices are expected to remain firm through the end of the month. Auctioneers Forbes, Ewart & Figgis said the CTC dust market remained strong, with 94 per cent of the offered quantity of 6,33,184 kg sold. All blenders together absorbed 66 per cent of the total CTC quantity sold. The orthodox dust market was also strong, with a sales percentage of 95 per cent of the offered quantity of 11,500 kg, with upcountry buyers and exporters absorbing the bulk of the quantity. The offered quantity of orthodox leaf was 1,90,432 kg, with 98 per cent sold, thanks to active support from CIS and Middle East buyers.

Cocoa rebounds after setting 2-1/2-year low

Reuters
London

London cocoa futures on the ICE turned higher after earlier slumping to a 2-1/2-year low. Arabica coffee and sugar prices also rose. London cocoa rose 0.5 per cent to £2,157 a tonne at 1118 GMT. The market is on track for a weekly loss of 16.5 per cent. New York cocoa gained 0.7 per cent to \$3,080 a tonne. **COFFEE, SUGAR** Arabica coffee rose 0.7 per cent to \$2,876 per lb, while robusta coffee lost 0.5 per cent to \$3,603 a tonne. Raw sugar gained 0.4 per cent to 14.13 cents per lb. The market slumped to a five-year low of 13.67 cents last week. White sugar rose 0.1 per cent to \$403.60 a tonne.

Bangkok-based Anan Jewels plans to expand its India operations

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Bangkok-based Anan Jewels plans to expand its operations in India, after having set up a manufacturing unit in Mumbai two years ago, its Director Ankita Kothari said. "We are growing every day. Just two years ago, we moved to this current building and now with the current market demands and the kind of supply we have to give to people, we are definitely looking at expanding to a bigger setup," she told *businessline* in an online interaction. The jewellery firm has huge demand for its products in India, which is a big market. It is one of the two big companies deliver-

ing natural colour diamonds in the country. Every product delivered and sold in India is designed, created and manufactured under one roof in Mumbai, she said. **B2B BRAND** The company will look at staying in Mumbai not because it is the business capital but because it is the easiest place to source diamonds in the country. "So, our raw material is more easily available here as compared to other cities. We are a business-to-business (B2B) brand and are working with 100-105 top jewellers in the country," said Kothari. Anan Jewels specialises in offering gold jewellery studied with natural colour diamonds. It has 100 artisans working in its Mumbai unit



Ankita Kothari, Director, Anan Jewels

have not impacted demand for the company's products. "Our product is something aspirational. People who look for our product are looking for an aspirational piece of jewellery which they can wear every day," said Kothari, adding that the ratio of precious metals in the company's jewellery is very low. Stating the current dip in precious metals prices is temporary, she said demand will emerge around the Diwali, wedding and Christmas seasons. On whether her company witnessed an increasing demand in diamonds when gold and silver prices surged, Kothari said there was at least a 20-30 per cent jump in people choosing diamond over gold in H2 2025. Soaring bullion prices

Experts flag risks to agri, policy space in India’s FTAs with US, EU

TRADE CONCERNS. ‘Free Trade Agreement expansion may boost exports, but at the cost of policy’

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Trade experts have raised wide-ranging concerns over India’s proposed and recently concluded free trade agreements (FTAs) with the US and the European Union, warning that the pacts could reshape key sectors, from agriculture and pharmaceuticals to automobiles and digital trade, while narrowing India’s policy space.

Speaking at a webinar titled ‘India’s Trade Agreements with EU and the US: Implications for India’s Economy and Society’ organised by Forum for Trade Justice, panelists cautioned that beyond tariff cuts, the agreements carry deep structural implications for regulation, sovereignty and long-term competitiveness.

PHARMA & PATENTS
On intellectual property and public health, Abhijit Das, independent trade policy analyst and former head, Centre for WTO Studies, warned that recent and proposed FTAs dilute critical policy tools that have enabled India

to maintain affordable access to medicines. Referring to the India-UK agreement, Das said it explicitly identifies voluntary licensing as the “preferred and optimal route” for promoting access to medicines. “Voluntary licensing involves the foreign patent holder entering into a licensing arrangement with an Indian manufacturer, possibly restricting quantities or setting high prices. This could result in expensive medicines or limited availability,” he said.

By contrast, compulsory licensing, permitted under the WTO’s TRIPS Agreement and India’s Patents Act, has been a crucial sovereign tool. “Compulsory licensing is a very important policy instrument to prevent misuse of patent monopoly power. It allows medicines to be manufactured domestically and sold at affordable prices,” Das stressed.

LEGALLY INTACT
He argued that even if compulsory licensing remains legally intact, FTA language signalling a preference for voluntary licensing effectively weakens its future use.



HEALTH CLAUSE. Referring to the India-UK agreement, Das said it explicitly identifies voluntary licensing as the “preferred and optimal route” for promoting access to medicines

Independent trade economist and former Jawaharlal Nehru University professor Biswajit Dhar flagged agriculture as a major area of concern, particularly in the India-US negotiations.

“In the case of the EU, at least from what we understand so far, core agricultural sectors remain protected,” he said. “But in the joint statement with the US, there is no clear articulation that sensitive agricultural products are excluded. Why is that not clearly stated? ”

Dhar warned that the absence of explicit safeguards

is troubling, especially given signals from Washington suggesting strong interest in accessing India’s farm market.

US IMPORTS
A key flashpoint is genetically modified (GM) products. The joint statement indicates that India has agreed to remove non-tariff barriers on US imports.

“GM has been a prominent barrier,” Dhar said.

“If all non-tariff barriers are removed without clarification, are we not to assume GM restrictions are in-

cluded? The US agricultural lobby’s celebration suggests they anticipate exporting GM crops to India.”

AGRI CONCESSIONS
Ajay Srivastava of the Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI) also pointed to ambiguities in agricultural concessions.

He noted confusion over references in US documents to pulses and DDGS imports, cautioning that such provisions could implicitly open the door to GM-linked products due to the lack of a clear GM-non-GM distinction in US exports.

Beyond IP, Das cautioned that sustainability chapters covering labour, gender and environment could effectively give partner countries oversight over India’s domestic regulatory framework.

Srivastava highlighted a little-noticed provision in the India-US joint statement committing both sides to “coordinate and act against non-market policies of third countries”, warning that it could have far-reaching implications for India’s foreign and economic policy.

Indian students that headed to the US halved in 2025 on high costs, visa issues

Yashaswani Chauhan
New Delhi

Indian student additions to the US halved in 2025, with net additions dropping 49.9 per cent year-on-year to 31,417. The slowdown from 62,679 additions in 2024 and the peak rise of 69,741 in 2023 signals a clear cooling after the post-pandemic spike.

DATA FOCUS.

Data from an Open Doors report show that while the overall base of Indian students in the US remains high, incremental growth has moderated significantly.

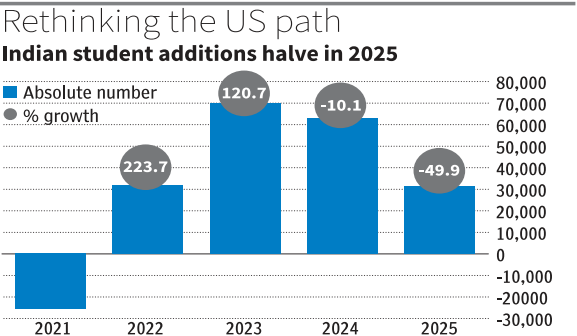
The surge in 2023 was largely driven by deferred pandemic demand, which temporarily inflated out-bound mobility. As that backlog cleared, expansion returned to more normal levels.

CURRENCY PRESSURES
Experts stated that rising tuition fees, higher living expenses and currency pressures have increased the overall cost of studying in the US, prompting families to adopt a more cautious approach. Immigration uncertainty and visa-processing delays have further influenced decision-making.

“The US continues to attract strong student interest. What we are witnessing is not declining aspiration, but more strategic decision-making. Students today are evaluating destinations through the lens of career outcomes, immigration clarity and financial viability,” said Ankit Mehra, CEO & Founder, GyanDhan.

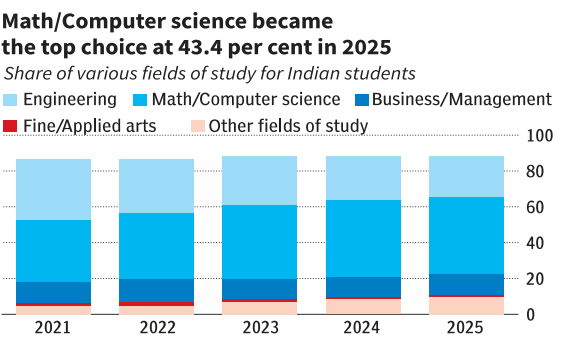
Even as overall growth moderates, enrolment patterns are shifting.

Optional practical training (OPT) additions surged from 874 in 2023 to 46,184 in 2025, an increase of over 5,000 per cent. The sharp



OPT emerges as key driver, jumps over 5,000% since 2023
Course-wise split of number of Indian students

Year	Academic level			
	UG	PG	Non-degree	OPT
2023	4,409	63,912	546	874
2024	4,099	30,631	-545	28,494
2025	4,082	-18,675	-174	46,184
% growth (2023-25)	-7	-129	-132	5184



Source: Open Doors report

jump highlights the growing importance of post-study work opportunities in enrolment decisions.

Experts stated that OPT has increasingly become central to the US study-abroad proposition, particularly for STEM aspirants seeking longer work authorisation.

In contrast, postgraduate additions turned negative in 2025, while undergraduate numbers remained broadly stable. Non-degree enrolments also declined, indicating a tilt towards employment-linked programmes.

CAREER PIVOT
Course preferences reflect this career-oriented pivot. Math and computer science accounted for 43.4 per cent

of Indian enrolments in 2025, up from 34.8 per cent in 2021. Engineering’s share declined to 22.8 per cent from 33.5 per cent over the same period.

Experts stated that the shift does not signal a decline in interest in engineering *per se*, but rather a move towards computing-intensive and AI-driven disciplines such as data science, cybersecurity and analytics, which align more directly with labour market demand and STEM-linked work benefits.

Looking ahead, experts indicated that growth will depend on immigration clarity, visa processing efficiency, cost trends, and competitive positioning from destinations such as the UK and Australia.

ISRO planning liquid methane plant to fuel next-gen rockets

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) plans to set up a liquid methane production plant at its propulsion complex, Mahendragiri, in Tamil Nadu.

Large, liquid-rocket propulsion systems utilising liquid methane and liquid oxygen are to be used as propellants to power the Next General Launch Vehicle (NGLV) that ISRO is developing.



HIGH CAPACITY. Large, liquid-rocket propulsion systems utilising liquid methane and liquid oxygen are to be used as propellants to power the NGLV that ISRO is developing

The NGLV, with high payload capability, for meeting the requirements of future space missions, is in line with National Space Vision. Unlike previous expendable launch vehicles, which were designed for a single use, the new vehicle introduces features of recovery and reuse in the first stage.

ISRO Propulsion Complex at Mahendragiri has invited expression of interest (EoI) from suitable parties for design, manufacturing, testing, supply, erection and commissioning of the liquid methane production plant at IPRC, Mahendragiri.

STATIC TESTS
Towards this objective, facilities are proposed to be established across ISRO centres. Liquid methane is required for performing static tests and launch operations.

NGLV, internally known as Project Soorya, is a three-stage, heavy-lift and partially reusable rocket under devel-

opment to replace PSLV and GSLV.

With a 30-tonne capacity to Low Earth Orbit, it focuses on cost-efficient, green, methalox-based (methane plus liquid oxygen) propulsion for future human spaceflight and commercial missions, with a maiden launch aimed for 2030-2032.

The EoI says that the contractor shall be responsible for establishment of liquid methane production plant of capacity eight tonne per day at IPRC, Mahendragiri for production of liquid methane of specified purity which involves following major activities: Liquid methane will be produced from liquefied natural gas as a raw material. Plant production process shall be optimum in all aspects, including less production cost and minimum wastage. An overall schematic of the plant proposed shall be submitted along with a tentative requirement

of LNG to produce 1 tonne of liquid methane.

WASTE GAS
In addition to that, the tentative quantity of consumables required and quantity of by-product and waste gas that will be generated shall also be furnished.

The vendor should have established a cryogenic production plant for producing cryogenic fluids viz liquid nitrogen/liquid oxygen/liquid hydrogen/liquid methane in their premises in the last seven years ending December 31, 2025. Alternatively, the vendor should have executed a contract/work involving manufacturing and supply of cryogenic systems such as double walled tanks/double walled pipelines for liquid nitrogen/liquid oxygen/liquid hydrogen/liquid methane service, including instrumentation and control systems in the last seven years ending December 3, 2025, the EoI said.

Air cargo sector wants double-dip facility back

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

The air cargo segment has sought the restoration of the double-dip facility for foreign carriers from the Centre, stating that India’s next growth phase is expected to come from Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities, industry insiders told *businessline*.

In aviation parlance, a double-dip facility means permitting a foreign freighter aircraft to operate to two Indian airports on a single international journey without undertaking domestic cargo carriage between them. According to letters written by the Air Cargo Forum India and other industry associations to the Ministry of Civil Aviation, the suspension of double-dip operations during the Covid-19 period led to a loss of over 10 per cent international freighter capacity. Other industry bodies as well as stakeholders have also written to the Centre seeking the reintroduction of such an arrangement.

BusinessLine has reviewed these communications.

GLOBAL PEERS
As per stakeholders, India currently has only 18 freighters in operation, placing it far behind global peers in dedicated cargo aircraft availability.

Meanwhile, double-dip operations allow a foreign freighter to serve two Indian airports on a single international trip without carrying domestic cargo.

This arrangement, according to stakeholders, makes routes viable for regional airports that are unable to fill an entire aircraft independently. Backing the proposal, Rajesh Menon, Regional Head of Cargo – South Asia, Middle East & Africa at Cathay Cargo, said: “The Cathay Group supports the reinstatement of the double-dip facility as a pragmatic measure aligned with India’s broader economic and trade growth ambitions.”

Apart from operational aspects, the communications state that export access linked to air cargo connectivity affects farmer incomes and related sectors.

EXPORT MARKETS
Industry estimates cited that access to export markets enables farmers to realise prices that are 1.5 to 3 times higher than those available domestically.

This translates into hundreds of dollars more per farmer annually, and into thousands of dollars for growers of high-value produce.

Emphasising the broader economic impact, Silveri Anil Kumar, Vice Chairman of the Federation of Freight Forwarders’ Associations in India (FFFAI), said: “Reinstating the double-dip facility for foreign freighters is the key to India’s air cargo resurgence. By unlocking global connectivity for Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities, this reform will boost exports, raise farmer incomes by 1.5-3x, and generate jobs in logistics and warehousing.”

Hindalco to supply aluminium to Embraer

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

Plane maker Embraer has signed an MoU with Hindalco to explore sourcing of aerospace grade aluminium from India.

This agreement builds upon Embraer’s existing product supply partnership with Hindalco’s US-based subsidiary Novelis and is a part of its strategy to widen its supply chains.

LOCAL PARTNERS
“This joint action reinforces our focus on identifying local partners that can become our suppliers and, in doing so, accelerate the development of the Indian industrial base,” said Roberto Chaves, Executive Vice-President of

Global Procurement and Supply Chain at Embraer.

“The initiative enhances Embraer’s engagement to advancing the aerospace ecosystem in India, creating long term value across the entire supply chain,” he added.

Embraer’s manufactured planes are flown by airlines, corporates and air forces around the world.

It has manufacturing facilities in Brazil and the US and is also looking to widen it’s manufacturing and supply chain footprint. This includes recent MoUs with Adani and Mahindra groups to explore manufacturing commercial and military aircraft in India. “India represents a strategic market for Embraer across all its business units,” it said.

Zoho eyes further expansion of its data centre footprint

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

As countries tighten data sovereignty norms, Zoho is looking to further expand its data centre footprint to support global growth, company executives said.

“The Zoho cloud data centres are monitored and managed by ManageEngine. More data centres are on the cards, the reason being that every country is coming up with data sovereignty requirements,” said Arun Kumar, Regional Vice President, Revenue & Growth, ManageEngine.

The company has data centres in countries including the US, Canada, Latin America, West Asia, Europe, the UK, the UAE, India, Japan, China and Australia.

India is among ManageEn-

gine’s top three markets, with nearly 10,000 customers.

While 70 per cent of its revenue in 2010 came from developed markets such as the US, Europe, and the UK, the company diversified over the past seven-eight years, opening regional offices across Southeast Asia, Latin America, West Asia and Africa, all of which are fast-growing, government-led digital transformation markets.

STILL GROWING
“Markets like the US and UK are still growing, but what used to contribute 70 per cent is now only contributing less than 45 per cent. Meanwhile, markets like India, Latin America, or Southeast Asia are growing at 25-35 per cent. The diversification has worked well; we’re



no longer concentrating on just one or two markets,” Kumar observed.

While the first 15 years of ManageEngine’s journey were largely focused on the SMB segment, the company has seen rising enterprise adoption over the past seven-eight years as its products have scaled.

In India, 70-80 per cent of revenue now comes from enterprise customers, though it continues to maintain a large SMB base.

Addressing the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act requirements,

Kumar said the issue must be viewed from two angles. As an Indian company serving domestic customers, Zoho must ensure compliance with the Act, with its processes and policies aligned accordingly.

GLOBAL STANDARDS
He noted that the company is already compliant with global standards such as GDPR and other regional certifications, and adheres to regulatory requirements across markets where it operates.

The second aspect, he said, is enabling customers to meet DPDP obligations. The Act places expectations around asset management, password policies, protection of personal data, regular audits, and demonstrable compliance through reports and validation.

Kumar said ManageEngine’s products help organisations meet these requirements by providing out-of-the-box reporting and compliance capabilities.

“The DPDP mandate to report breaches within a short timeframe requires organisations to generate detailed forensic incident reports, identify infected devices, trace attacker movement, assess exposure of sensitive data, and determine the overall impact,” said Romanus Prabhu Raymond, Director of Technology at ManageEngine.

IMPACT ASSESSMENT
“This calls for the right mix of people, processes and tools. We provide visibility into the attack path, impact assessment, containment measures, and overall resilience to help organisations

meet these compliance requirements.”

With close to 6,000 employees and over 30 offices globally, ManageEngine is expanding its customer-facing functions both in India and overseas. However, on the engineering and product development front, the company is taking a measured approach as it closely tracks how AI evolves.

Addressing the recent hype around AI and its potential effect on software, Rakesh Jayaprakash, Product Head, ManageEngine, said, “With something as cutting-edge as AI, there will be opportunities, which may appear as a threat. While we wait and watch, we also keep up with the developments. We spend about 40 per cent of our revenue on R&D, and our AI initiatives started in the late 2000s.”

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